



The Complete Apartment Growing Guide

Indoor growing, balcony gardens, grow lights, and jar gardening

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The Complete Apartment Growing Guide

Every Plant for Every Space — Indoors, Outdoors, Jars, and Under Lights

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You do not need land. You do not need a yard. You need the right plant in the right spot with the right care. This guide covers everything: the shady corner, the sunny balcony, the mason jar on the windowsill, the grow light over the kitchen counter. Whatever space you have, something will grow there.

Important Notice

This guide is educational content based on real growing experience. Your results will vary depending on your specific light conditions, apartment environment, and local climate. It is not professional agricultural advice. Use it as a practical starting point and adapt based on what you observe in your own space.

How to Use This Guide

This guide is organized by **growing environment**, not by plant type. Before buying anything, identify your space:

1. Indoor — No Grow Light: What direction do your windows face? How many hours of light reaches your plants?
2. Outdoor — Balcony or Window Box: Is it south-facing and open, or north-facing and shaded?
3. Jars and Bottles: Counter space plus a little water and patience.
4. Indoor — With a Grow Light: The great equalizer. Opens up nearly everything.

Read the section that matches your situation. Each entry tells you what the plant actually needs, not what the tag at the garden center claims.

Light Explained

Full Sun / Direct Sun — 6+ hours of direct sunlight per day. A south- or west-facing outdoor space. Nothing blocked between the plant and the sky.

Bright Indirect — Near a window, light but no direct sun rays on the leaves. East-facing windows, filtered south-facing windows, or 3–5 feet back from a sunny window. About 2–4 hours of ambient bright light.

Indirect / Moderate — A few feet from a window. Light reaches the room but doesn't land on the plant.

North-facing windows qualify here. Some rooms with east windows in winter.

Low Light / Shade — Dim rooms with no direct window exposure. Artificial light from household bulbs only. Very few plants thrive here; most merely survive.

Pet Safety Guide

Throughout this guide, pet safety warnings appear inline. A summary of all toxic plants is provided in Section 5 (Tools & Care). Symbols used:

- TOXIC TO CATS AND DOGS — Keep out of reach or avoid entirely
- TOXIC TO CATS — Dogs generally tolerate; cats do not
- MILDLY TOXIC — Causes GI upset if ingested; not typically fatal in small amounts
- TOXIC — SEEDS / ROOTS ONLY — The plant is safe; specific parts are not

When in doubt, consult the ASPCA Animal Poison Control Center: aspca.org/pet-care/animal-poison-control

SECTION ONE: INDOOR PLANTS — NO GROW LIGHT

These plants are organized by how much light they actually need. The distinction between "bright indirect" and "low light" determines whether an edible plant produces anything worth eating, and whether a decorative plant grows or just slowly declines.

PART A: BRIGHT INDIRECT LIGHT

East-facing windows, south-facing windows with a sheer curtain, or any spot within 3–4 feet of a large south or west window. Roughly 2–4 hours of ambient bright light per day. No direct sun on the leaves.

EDIBLE PLANTS — BRIGHT INDIRECT

Mint (*Mentha* spp.)

The most forgiving edible you can grow indoors. Aggressive, adaptable, and useful every single week.

Light	Bright indirect; tolerates low indirect
Water	Keep consistently moist; does not like t
Temperature	55–75°F; tolerates cool rooms well
Container	6–12" pot (or a dedicated container — mi
Display	Windowsill, hanging planter, kitchen cou
Notes	Grow each variety separately — they will

Varieties

- Peppermint (*M. × piperita*) — The classic. Strong menthol flavor. Tea, cocktails, baking.
- Spearmint (*M. spicata*) — Milder and sweeter than peppermint. Mojitos, tabbouleh, lamb.
- Apple Mint (*M. suaveolens*) — Soft fuzzy leaves, mild fruity-mint flavor. Excellent for jelly, tea, and fruit salads.
- Chocolate Mint (*M. × piperita* 'Chocolate') — Hints of chocolate and peppermint. Desserts, hot chocolate, homemade extracts.
- Pineapple Mint (*M. suaveolens* 'Variegata') — Variegated white-green leaves, fruity aroma. More decorative than flavorful; still usable in drinks.
- Lemon Mint (*M. × piperita* f. *citrata*) — Citrus-forward flavor. Excellent in water, tea, and fish dishes.
- Pennyroyal (*M. pulegium*) — Strong medicinal mint. Use sparingly; not safe in large quantities or during pregnancy.
- Water Mint (*M. aquatica*) — Native to wet areas; excellent in a jar of water or very wet conditions.
- Vietnamese Mint / Hot Mint (*Persicaria odorata*) — Not a true *Mentha* but behaves similarly. Sharp, peppery-mint flavor. Essential in Vietnamese cuisine. Prefers warmth and humidity.
- Catnip (*Nepeta cataria*) — Related to mint; easy to grow. Tea for humans, enrichment for cats. Mild sedative effect.

Detailed Care

Mint is one of the easiest edibles to keep alive in an apartment. It prefers moist soil — let it dry slightly between waterings, but not completely. In a small pot in a warm room, you may need to water every 2–3 days. In a larger pot in a cooler room, once a week may be enough.

Harvest by snipping the top 2–3 inches of growth. This encourages branching. Never harvest more than one-third of the plant at once. Mint will send out runners underground and can take over a shared pot — grow it alone or in a dedicated hanging planter.

Mint will tolerate lower light than most edibles but will become leggy and less flavorful. A windowsill is always better than a shelf three feet away.

Propagation: Cuttings root in water in 5–7 days. Dig up and replant runners. Mint is nearly impossible to kill.

Common Problems

- Leggy, pale stems reaching toward window: Insufficient light — move closer or rotate
- Wilting despite moist soil: Root rot from poor drainage — check pot holes; reduce watering
- White powdery coating on leaves: Powdery mildew — increase airflow, reduce humidity around foliage, trim affected sections

Chives (*Allium schoenoprasum*)

The most reliable indoor allium. Mild onion flavor available year-round with almost no effort.

Light	Bright indirect; performs best near east
Water	Allow top inch to dry between waterings
Temperature	60–75°F; tolerates cool conditions
Container	6–8" pot; can grow multiple plants toget
Display	Windowsill, kitchen counter
Notes	Will go dormant and die back in winter —

Varieties

- Common Chives (*A. schoenoprasum*) — Thin hollow grass-like leaves. Mild onion. Lavender edible flowers in spring.
- Garlic Chives (*A. tuberosum*) — Flat leaves, stronger garlic flavor. White flowers. Excellent in stir-fry, dumplings, noodles.
- Siberian Chives (*A. nutans*) — Wider flat leaves, subtle flavor. Less common but very cold-tolerant.

Detailed Care

Snip leaves at the base, leaving 1–2 inches of growth. The plant will regrow from the bottom. Unlike many herbs, chives improve with frequent cutting — let them grow 6 inches, then cut back to 2 inches. Repeat.

Feed monthly with a diluted liquid fertilizer during active growth. Repot every 1–2 years as the clumps get dense. Divide when overcrowded.

Propagation: Divide clumps every 1–2 years or start from seed in a container with good drainage.

Parsley (*Petroselinum crispum*)

A slow starter that rewards patience. One plant provides garnish and cooking herbs for months.

Light	Bright indirect preferred; tolerates mod
Water	Keep consistently moist; does not like t
Temperature	60–75°F; cooler is fine
Container	8–10" pot, at least 8" deep (parsley has
Display	Windowsill, kitchen counter
Notes	Biennial — blooms in year two, then dies

Varieties

- Flat-Leaf / Italian Parsley (*P. crispum* var. *neapolitanum*) — More flavorful. Best for cooking.
- Curly Parsley (*P. crispum*) — Decorative. Milder flavor. Good garnish.
- Hamburg Parsley (*P. crispum* var. *tuberosum*) — Grown for the edible root, which tastes like parsley-flavored parsnip. Needs a deep container (12"+).

Detailed Care

Parsley is slow to germinate — 3–4 weeks from seed is normal. Buy a transplant to skip this frustration. Once established, it grows steadily. Harvest outer stalks from the base; leave the central growth intact. The plant can produce harvestable leaves for 12–18 months before bolting.

Do not let parsley sit in waterlogged soil — a deep pot with excellent drainage prevents root rot.

Lemon Balm (*Melissa officinalis*)

Fragrant, lemon-scented herb that makes excellent tea and grows effortlessly in indirect light.

Light	Bright indirect; tolerates moderate ligh
Water	Moderate; allow top inch to dry between
Temperature	60–80°F
Container	8–10" pot
Display	Windowsill, shelf near window

Lemon balm is in the mint family and spreads aggressively if allowed. Use fresh or dried leaves for calming tea, lemon-flavored water, salad dressings, and desserts. Harvest regularly to prevent flowering, which diminishes leaf flavor. An extremely low-maintenance herb that asks almost nothing.



Sorrel (*Rumex acetosa* / *R. scutatus*)

Tart, lemony leaves that grow year-round and ask for almost nothing. Criminally underused.

Light	Bright indirect; tolerates shade better
Water	Moderate; evenly moist
Temperature	50–75°F; prefers cooler conditions
Container	8–10" pot
Display	Windowsill, any bright spot

Varieties

- Garden Sorrel (*R. acetosa*) — Large arrow-shaped leaves. Strongly sour. Use like spinach in soups, sauces, salads.
- French Sorrel (*R. scutatus*) — Smaller shield-shaped leaves, milder and more nuanced flavor. Chef's favorite for sorrel soup and cream sauces.
- Red-Veined Sorrel (*R. sanguineus*) — Striking red veins. Milder flavor. Excellent in salads.
- Sheep's Sorrel (*R. acetosella*) — Small, very tart, invasive. Keep contained.

Harvest young leaves for best flavor; older leaves become tougher and more intensely sour. Cut flowering stalks immediately to keep leaf production going. Sorrel is perennial and will regrow from roots for years.

Chervil (*Anthriscus cerefolium*)

The forgotten herb. Delicate anise-parsley flavor, thrives in cooler conditions and indirect light.

Light	Indirect to bright indirect; prefers par
Water	Keep consistently moist
Temperature	45–65°F; bolts quickly in heat — a cool
Container	6–8" pot
Display	North window in warm months; any bright

A classic French herb for fines herbes (alongside chives, parsley, and tarragon). Use fresh — heat destroys its flavor. Essential for béarnaise, scrambled eggs, and spring salads. Direct seed into the container; it dislikes transplanting. Sow every 6–8 weeks for continuous harvest.



Vietnamese Coriander / Rau Ram (*Persicaria odorata*)

Sharp, peppery, with a hint of cilantro. Heat-tolerant and grows well in indirect light.

Light	Bright indirect; tolerates moderate indi
Water	Keep moist; does not like to dry out
Temperature	65-85°F; tropical – does not tolerate co
Container	6-8" pot
Display	Warm windowsill

Essential in Vietnamese pho, laksa, salads, and herb plates. A great substitute for cilantro (which bolts quickly indoors). Harvest the top leaves; the plant branches and regrows readily. Propagates easily from cuttings in water.

Perilla / Shiso (*Perilla frutescens*)

A beautiful herb that doubles as a decorative plant. Essential in Japanese and Korean cooking.

Light	Bright indirect; will tolerate moderate
Water	Keep moist; do not allow to dry complete
Temperature	65-85°F
Container	8-10" pot
Display	Windowsill; the purple variety is striki

Varieties

- Green Shiso (*P. frutescens* var. *crispa*) — Bright flavor, essential in sushi, sashimi, Japanese salads. Wrap around rice balls.
- Red/Purple Shiso (*P. frutescens* var. *purpurea*) — Deep purple, slightly more robust flavor. Used in umeboshi plums, Korean dishes, as a garnish.
- Bicolor Shiso — Green on top, purple underneath. Decorative and edible.

Pinch flowering stems to keep leaf production going. Harvest outer leaves from the base. The flavor is a complex blend of anise, mint, and citrus.



Green Onions / Scallions (*Allium cepa* / *A. fistulosum*)

The easiest edible to grow indoors. Regrow from grocery store scraps in water or soil within days.

Light	Bright indirect; will grow in lower light
Water	Keep moist if in soil; change water ever
Temperature	55–75°F
Container	4–6" glass or pot; bunching varieties ca
Display	Kitchen counter, windowsill

Growing Methods

1. Regrow from scraps in water: Place grocery store scallion root ends (1–2" of white base) in a glass with 1" of water. Green tops regrow in 3–5 days. Harvest the tops repeatedly; change water every 2 days.
2. Grow in soil from transplant or seed: Plant bunching onions in a 6" pot. Harvest individual stalks from the outside as they reach 8–10 inches. The plant will continue producing.

Varieties for Containers

- Evergreen Hardy White — Compact, bunching, perennial.
- White Lisbon — Fast-growing from seed; best for continuous harvest.
- Parade — Upright and tidy; good windowsill variety.
- Red Beard — Red-tinged; slightly milder flavor; decorative.

Watercress (*Nasturtium officinale*)

Peppery aquatic green that grows in a shallow tray of water. No soil required.

Light	Bright indirect; does not need direct su
Water	Grows in water — keep roots submerged; r
Temperature	50–70°F; prefers cool conditions
Container	Shallow tray, bowl, or jar with 2–4" of
Display	Windowsill, kitchen counter

Place watercress cuttings or transplants in a shallow container with room-temperature water. Roots will anchor in the water. Change water every 2–3 days to prevent stagnation. Harvest tops regularly; the plant will branch and regrow. Watercress is rich in vitamins C, K, and beta-carotene. Use in salads, sandwiches, smoothies, and as a garnish.

Note: Tap water with chlorine can be used; let it sit uncovered for 24 hours before use, or use filtered water.

Stevia (Stevia rebaudiana)

A natural sweetener 200x sweeter than sugar, growing in a pot on your windowsill.

Light	Bright indirect preferred; tolerates mod
Water	Keep moist; do not allow to dry out
Temperature	65-85°F; tropical – keep above 60°F
Container	8-10" pot
Display	Warm windowsill

Chew a single fresh leaf and the sweetness is immediate and remarkable. Use fresh leaves in tea and drinks. Dry and crush leaves for a powdered sweetener. Stevia will bolt (flower) indoors – pinch flower buds to maintain leaf quality. Propagate from stem cuttings rooted in water.



Bay Laurel (*Laurus nobilis*)

A slow-growing Mediterranean herb tree that eventually becomes a centerpiece plant – and gives you fresh bay leaves forever.

Light	Bright indirect; will adapt to moderate
Water	Allow soil to dry halfway between wateri
Temperature	55–80°F; can tolerate brief cool spells
Container	Start in 8–10"; repot as it grows – can
Display	Corner near window; can be trained as a

Bay laurel is a patient investment. It grows slowly – do not expect to harvest heavily for the first year. Once established, pick individual leaves as needed. Dried bay leaves have more concentrated flavor; fresh leaves are milder. Bay is a staple in stocks, braises, soups, and curries.

Lettuce — Loose Leaf Varieties (*Lactuca sativa*)

Fastest crop for bright indirect indoor spaces. Ready to harvest in 4–6 weeks from transplant.

Light	Bright indirect; will tolerate moderate
Water	Keep consistently moist
Temperature	55–70°F; bolts above 75°F — cooler rooms
Container	Shallow window box or 8–12" pot (6" dept)
Display	Windowsill, window box, hanging planter

Best Varieties for Indoor Bright Indirect

- Oakleaf — Lobed leaves, slow to bolt, excellent flavor
- Black Seeded Simpson — Very fast; large ruffled leaves; mild flavor
- Tom Thumb — True mini lettuce; compact heads; perfect for 4–6" pots
- Salad Bowl — Loose-leaf rosette; harvest outer leaves continuously
- Freckles / Flashy Trout's Back — Spotted red-green leaves; decorative and tasty
- Butterhead varieties (Bibb, Boston) — More compact; need slightly more light than loose-leaf types

Detailed Care

Use the "cut and come again" method: harvest outer leaves when they reach 4–6 inches, leaving the center intact. The plant will continuously produce new leaves for 6–10 weeks before eventually bolting (sending up a flower stalk). When you see a flower stalk forming, the leaves will turn bitter — harvest everything at that point and start a new container.

Lettuce bolts quickly in warm rooms or when root-bound. Keep the root zone cool and do not let water sit in saucers.

Spinach (*Spinacia oleracea*)

A cool-weather crop that does well in bright indirect light when temperatures stay below 70°F.

Light	Bright indirect
Water	Keep consistently moist
Temperature	45–68°F; bolts quickly above 75°F
Container	8–12" pot or window box; at least 6" dee
Display	Cool windowsill — north-facing windows i

Varieties for Containers

- Bloomsdale Longstanding — Savoy (crinkled) leaves; slow to bolt; excellent flavor
- Space — Compact, upright; bred for container growing
- Giant Noble — Large smooth leaves; fast; good for cutting
- Baby's Leaf — Harvest as microgreens or baby spinach; very quick crop

Like lettuce, use cut-and-come-again harvest. Cool rooms (55–65°F) dramatically extend the harvest window. A north-facing windowsill in winter is nearly ideal for spinach.



Arugula (*Eruca vesicaria* subsp. *sativa*)

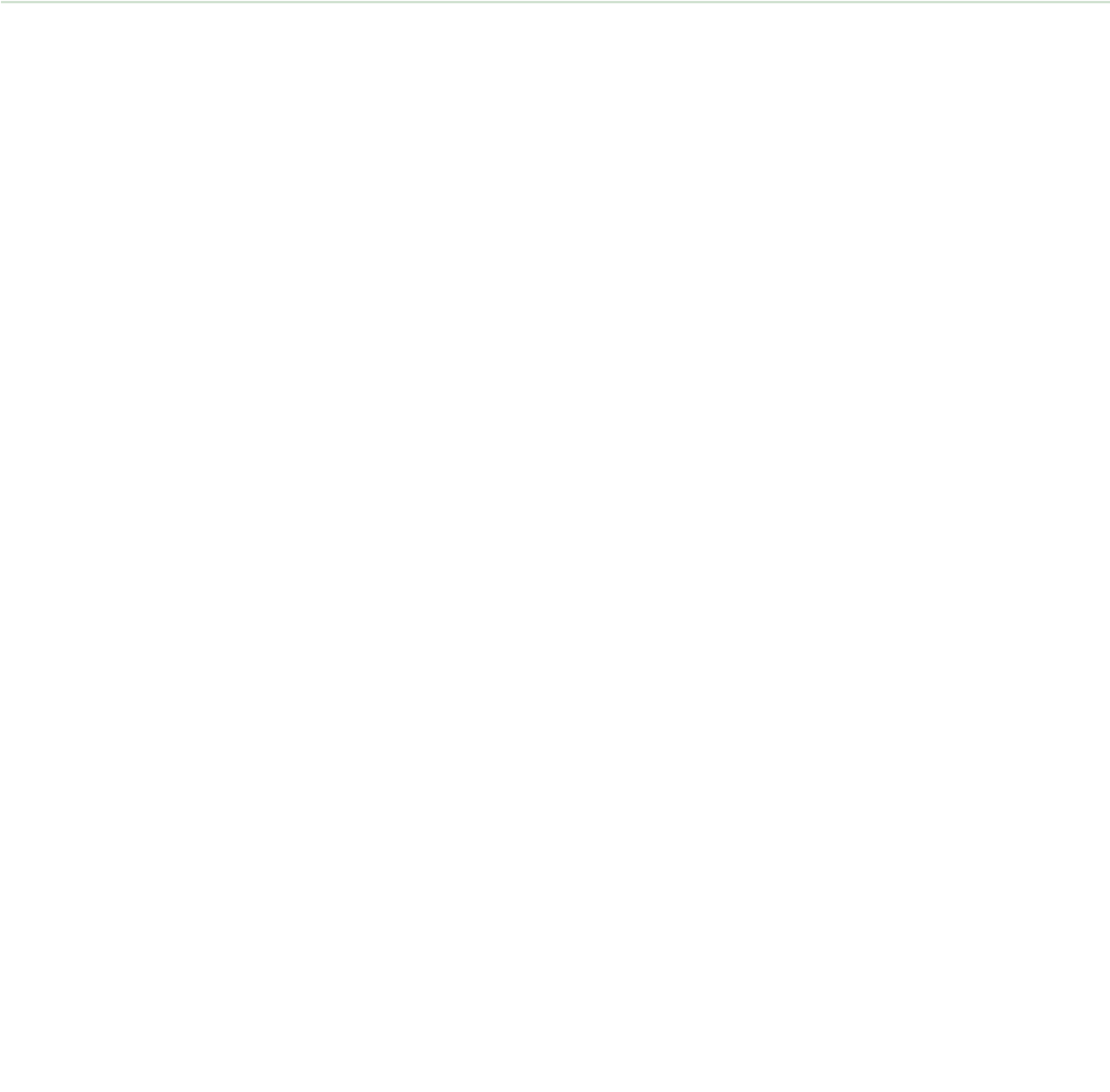
Peppery, fast-growing, and happy in indirect light. Ready to harvest in 3–4 weeks.

Light	Bright indirect; tolerates moderate
Water	Keep moist
Temperature	45–65°F; bolts quickly in heat
Container	Shallow box or 8" pot
Display	Cool windowsill

Varieties

- Standard / Roquette — Classic peppery flavor; fast
- Wild Arugula (*Diplotaxis tenuifolia*) — More deeply lobed, more pungent, slower to bolt (perennial in mild climates)
- Astro — Mild, heat-tolerant; good for warmer apartments

Direct seed into containers and thin to 2–3" spacing. Baby leaves (2–3") are mildest; mature leaves (4–5") are more peppery. Bolt at first sign of flowers by harvesting everything.



Swiss Chard (*Beta vulgaris* subsp. *cicla*)

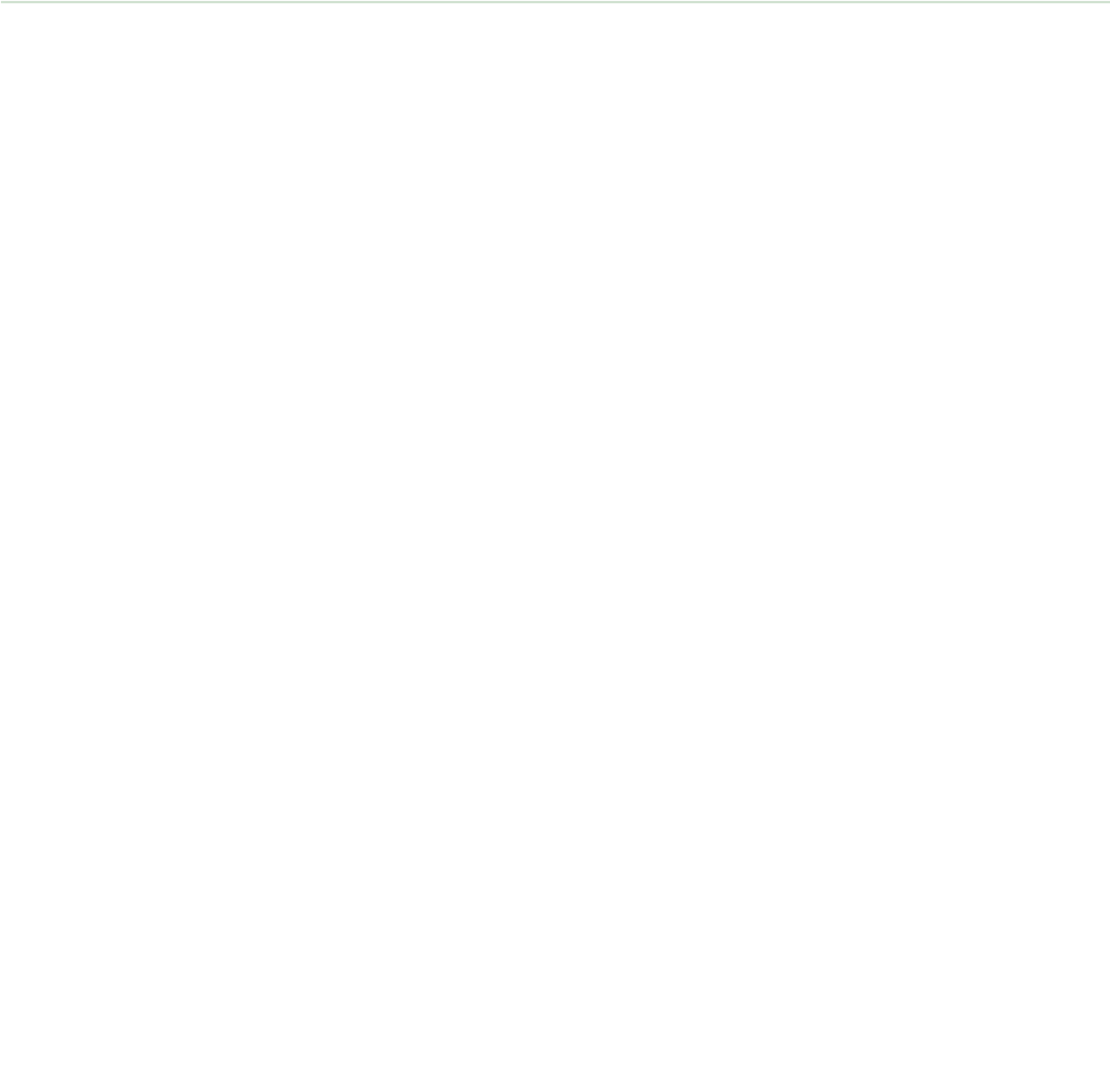
More light-tolerant than spinach. Colorful stems make it as decorative as it is useful.

Light	Bright indirect; tolerates moderate bett
Water	Keep moist; does not like to dry complet
Temperature	55–75°F
Container	10–12" pot, at least 8" deep
Display	Windowsill; the bright stems make it a v

Varieties

- Rainbow Chard — Mix of red, yellow, orange, and pink stems; spectacular
- Fordhook Giant — Large white stems; classic flavor; the most productive
- Ruby Red / Rhubarb Chard — Deep red stems; beautiful; slightly earthier flavor
- Bright Lights — Similar to Rainbow; uniform plants

Harvest outer leaves and stems from the base; the center will continue producing. A single plant provides ongoing harvests for months. Use stems and leaves separately — stems take longer to cook.



Microgreens (Various species)

The fastest edible in this guide. First harvest in 7–14 days. Requires almost no space.

Light	Bright indirect; even artificial overhea
Water	Bottom-water (fill tray below growing tr
Temperature	60–75°F
Container	Shallow trays (10"x20" standard propagat
Display	Counter, shelf, any flat surface with so

Best Microgreen Varieties

- Sunflower — Large, crunchy, nutty; popular for salads and as a snack
- Pea shoots — Tendrils; sweet, fresh; very fast (7–10 days)
- Radish — Spicy; very fast (5–7 days); striking pink or purple stems
- Broccoli — Mild; extremely high in sulforaphane (a potent anti-cancer compound)
- Arugula — Peppery; fast; excellent on pizza and pasta
- Red cabbage — Striking purple; slightly spicy
- Mustard — Spicy/zingy; fast
- Kale — Mild kale flavor; highly nutritious
- Amaranth — Beautiful magenta; mild
- Basil — Aromatic but slow (14–21 days); very rewarding
- Cilantro — Slow; soak seeds for 12 hours first to speed germination
- Beet — Earthy; striking red color; eat both leaf and stem
- Buckwheat — Mild, slightly nutty; very decorative
- Fenugreek — Strong maple-like flavor; used in Indian cooking; fast

Growing Method

1. Fill shallow tray with 1–2" of potting mix or coir/hemp growing mat
2. Spread seeds densely (check package for density — varies by variety)
3. Mist with water, cover with another tray (for darkness and humidity)
4. Check daily; remove cover when seeds sprout and reach 1–2"
5. Move to light; harvest when first true leaves appear (or at cotyledon stage for some varieties)
6. Harvest with scissors at soil level; rinse and eat immediately

No soil needed for some varieties (radish, pea shoots, sunflower): use a damp paper towel or hemp mat.

Nasturtiums (*Tropaeolum majus*)

Edible flowers, edible leaves, and edible seeds. Cheerful in indirect light, stunning in sun.

Light	Bright indirect minimum; more light = mo
Water	Allow to dry slightly between waterings;
Temperature	55-75°F
Container	8-12" pot; trailing varieties spill over
Display	Hanging planter, window box, windowsill

Varieties

- Trailing/Climbing types (Alaska, Whirlybird) – Vine-like; good in hanging baskets; 2-3 feet of trailing growth
- Compact types (Tom Thumb, Jewel Mix) – More restrained; better for pots on sills
- Canary Creeper (*T. peregrinum*) – Yellow fringed flowers; vigorous climber

Flowers, leaves, and immature seeds are all edible. Flowers have a peppery, honey-sweet flavor. Use in salads, as garnish, or stuff with cream cheese. Pickle the unripe seeds as a caper substitute. Nasturtiums in indirect light will produce some flowers but will lean aggressively toward the light. In brighter light, they bloom prolifically.



Kale (*Brassica oleracea* var. *acephala*)

Compact dwarf varieties grow well in bright indirect light. Cold-tolerant and extremely nutritious.

Light	Bright indirect (more is better but it t
Water	Keep consistently moist
Temperature	45–75°F; flavor improves after a cold sp
Container	10–12" pot, at least 8" deep
Display	Windowsill

Compact Varieties

- Dwarf Blue Scotch Curled — Very compact; tight curly leaves; good flavor
- Red Russian — More open habit; tender flat leaves; best flavor; lower light tolerance
- Nero di Toscana / Lacinato / Dinosaur Kale — Strap-like dark blue-green leaves; elegant; excellent for pasta and soups
- Redbor — Deep purple-red; highly ornamental AND productive
- Baby Kale mix — Harvest young leaves at baby-leaf stage for salads

Harvest the lowest, oldest outer leaves and let the center continue growing. A single plant can produce for months.

DECORATIVE PLANTS — BRIGHT INDIRECT

Pothos (Epipremnum aureum)

TOXIC TO CATS AND DOGS — causes oral irritation, vomiting, and drooling if ingested. Keep out of reach; not suitable for homes with pets that chew plants.

The single most popular houseplant for a reason. Grows in almost any indoor condition. Trails dramatically.

Light	Bright indirect to low light; adapts to
Water	Allow top half of soil to dry between wa
Temperature	60–85°F
Container	6–8" pot; any container with drainage
Display	High shelf (trailing), hanging planter,

Varieties

- Golden Pothos (E. aureum) — Yellow-green variegation; the classic
- Marble Queen — White and green marbled; striking
- Neon Pothos — Bright chartreuse-green; vivid color in low light
- Pearls and Jade — Green and white speckled; slower growing
- Cebu Blue — Silver-blue sheen; stunning; slightly slower growing
- Manjula — Wide, wavy leaves with cream and green
- Baltic Blue — Darker green; develops fenestrations (holes) in mature leaves
- Njoy — Small, crisp white-and-green leaves; compact

Detailed Care

Pothos is truly hard to kill. It tolerates low light (with loss of variegation), irregular watering, and forgotten fertilizing. It excels when given bright indirect light and watered when the top 2 inches of soil are dry.

Trails up to 10 feet from a hanging planter; can be trained up a moss pole for an upright form. Trim long vines to keep tidy; root cuttings in water to propagate indefinitely.

Philodendron (Philodendron spp.)

TOXIC TO CATS AND DOGS — insoluble calcium oxalates cause oral irritation, swelling, and GI distress if ingested.

Lush tropical foliage with a huge range of forms — trailing, climbing, upright, large-leaf, and compact.

Light	Bright indirect; tolerates moderate
Water	Allow top inch to dry between waterings
Temperature	65–85°F
Container	6–12" depending on variety; climbers do
Display	Shelf, moss pole planter, hanging basket

Varieties

- Heartleaf Philodendron (*P. hederaceum*) — The classic trailing variety. Tolerates very low light. Extremely forgiving.
- Brasil (*P. hederaceum* 'Brasil') — Yellow and green variegated heartleaf. Striking.
- Split-Leaf / Swiss Cheese Plant — See Monstera below
- Velvet Leaf Philodendron (*P. hederaceum* var. *hederaceum*) — Velvety dark green with bronze undersides
- Pink Princess (*P. erubescens* 'Pink Princess') — Stunning pink variegation; high demand, high price
- Birkin (*P. 'Birkin'*) — White pinstripes on dark green leaves; compact, upright
- Xanadu (*P. xanadu*) — Deeply lobed, compact, architectural; does not climb
- Gloriosum (*P. gloriosum*) — Enormous velvety heart-shaped leaves with cream veins; terrestrial
- Melanochrysum (*P. melanochrysum*) — Dark, velvety, almost black-green leaves; climber
- Squamiferum (*P. squamiferum*) — Unusual hairy red petioles; lobed leaves
- White Wave / Billietiae — Long, narrow corrugated leaves
- Lemon Lime (*P. hederaceum* 'Lemon Lime') — Bright acid-green new growth fading to lime

Monstera (Monstera spp.)

MILDLY TOXIC TO CATS AND DOGS – insoluble calcium oxalates; causes oral irritation and GI upset.

The iconic statement plant. Develops its famous "Swiss cheese" holes as it matures.

Light	Bright indirect; tolerates moderate
Water	Allow top 2" to dry between waterings
Temperature	65–85°F
Container	Start in 10–12"; repot as it grows; large
Display	Floor planter, moss pole, corner statement

Varieties

- Monstera deliciosa – The classic. Leaves can reach 3 feet wide in good conditions. Needs a moss pole to grow upright.
- Monstera adansonii (Swiss Cheese Vine) – Smaller leaves with more holes relative to size; trails or climbs; faster growing.
- Monstera dubia – Shingles against a wall or pole; juvenile leaves tiny, adult leaves large. Collector plant.
- Monstera siltepecana – Silvery-grey leaves with dark veins; compact; trails.
- Monstera Thai Constellation – Cream and green variegation; extremely slow growing; very expensive.
- Monstera albo (Albo Borsigiana) – White and green variegation; faster growing than Thai Constellation.

Note on Fenestrations: The holes and splits develop only when the plant receives sufficient light. A Monstera in low light will produce plain, non-fenestrated leaves. Give it a bright spot.



Peace Lily (*Spathiphyllum* spp.)

TOXIC TO CATS AND DOGS – insoluble calcium oxalates cause oral irritation, excessive drooling, difficulty swallowing. Also mildly toxic to humans if ingested.

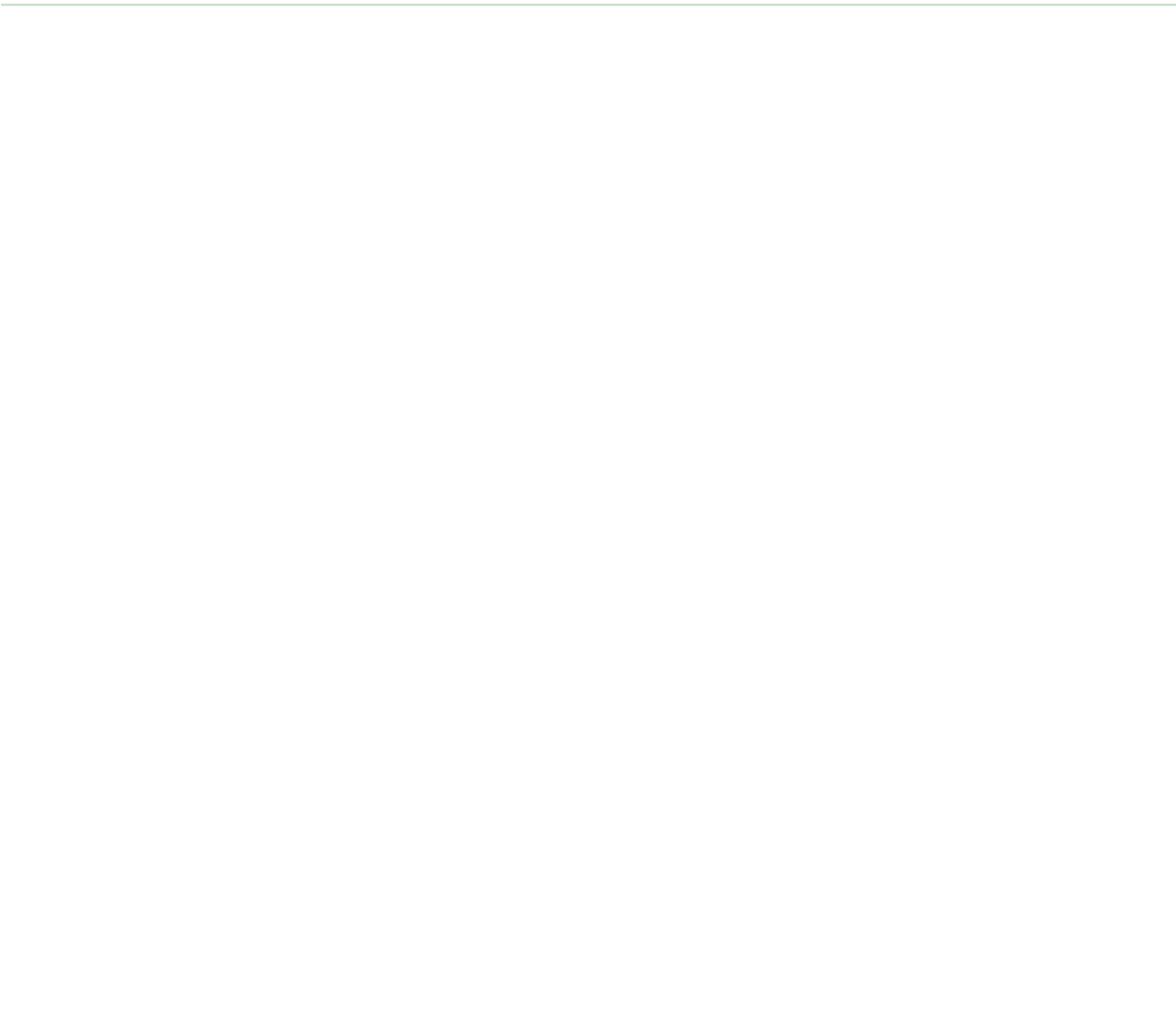
One of the few flowering plants that thrives in low-to-moderate indirect light.

Light	Moderate to bright indirect; flowers bes
Water	Keep consistently moist; wilts dramatica
Temperature	65–80°F
Container	6–10" depending on variety
Display	Shelf, table, floor planter for larger v

Varieties

- Standard Peace Lily – White spathes; 18–24" tall
- Mauna Loa Supreme – Larger leaves and flowers; can reach 3–4 feet
- Petite – Compact 12" version; good for small spaces
- Sensation – Giant; leaves up to 20" long; impressive floor plant
- Domino – Variegated white-and-green leaves

Peace lilies are one of the top air-purifying houseplants. They droop dramatically when thirsty but recover quickly after watering – this makes watering easy to read. Wipe leaves occasionally to remove dust.



Spider Plant (Chlorophytum comosum)

Safe for pets. Produces cascading "spiderettes" that can be rooted in water. Nearly impossible to kill.

Light	Bright indirect; tolerates moderate to l
Water	Allow top inch to dry between waterings
Temperature	60-80°F
Container	6-8"; hanging planter shows off the trai
Display	Hanging basket, high shelf, macramé hang

Varieties

- Standard (C. comosum) – Solid green leaves
- Variegated (C. comosum 'Vittatum') – Green leaves with cream center stripe; the most common
- Reverse Variegated (C. comosum 'Variegatum') – Green center, cream edges
- Curly / Bonnie (C. comosum 'Bonnie') – Curled, compact foliage; very tidy; excellent in small pots
- Ocean – Compact; good for limited spaces

The "spiderettes" (baby plants on long runners) can be pinched off and rooted in a glass of water, then potted up. Prolific propagator – one spider plant can produce dozens of offspring per year.



Calathea, Maranta & Prayer Plants (Calathea / Maranta / Goeppertia spp.)

Safe for pets. Leaves move throughout the day — rising and lowering in response to light. Beautiful patterns.

Light	Bright indirect to moderate; no direct s
Water	Keep moist; sensitive to chlorine — use
Temperature	65–80°F; no drafts or cold spots
Container	6–10"
Display	Table, shelf, bathroom (loves humidity)
Humidity	High — mist regularly, use a pebble tray

Varieties

- Maranta leuconeura (Prayer Plant) — Classic folding leaves; red veins on green background; very tolerant
- Maranta leuconeura 'Kerchoveana' — Rabbit tracks pattern; pale green with dark green spots
- Calathea ornata — Thin white pinstripes on dark green; elegant
- Calathea medallion — Large round leaves with intricate medallion pattern; purple underside
- Calathea rattlesnake (Goeppertia insignis) — Long wavy leaves with alternating dark spots; dramatic
- Calathea zebrina — Bold zebra stripes; one of the largest calatheas
- Calathea musaica / Network (Goeppertia kegeljanii) — Fine geometric grid pattern; unusual
- Calathea orbifolia — Large, round, silvery-green striped leaves; stunning
- Ctenanthe setosa 'Grey Star' — Grey-green with fine pattern; very tolerant
- Stromanthe sanguinea 'Triostar' — Cream, pink, and green leaves with magenta undersides; dramatic

Ferns — Indoor Varieties (Various genera)

Safe for pets. Lush, textural, and thriving in the indirect light conditions that challenge other plants.

Light	Bright indirect to moderate; no direct s
Water	Keep consistently moist; high humidity e
Temperature	60–75°F
Container	6–12" with excellent drainage
Display	Hanging basket, bathroom shelf, pedestal
Humidity	High — ferns decline in dry apartments;

Varieties

- Boston Fern (*Nephrolepis exaltata*) — Arching fronds; classic hanging basket plant; very popular; needs high humidity
- Kimberly Queen Fern (*Nephrolepis oblitterata*) — More upright and tidy than Boston fern; more tolerant of dry air
- Bird's Nest Fern (*Asplenium nidus*) — Rosette of wide, undivided fronds; more tolerant of dry conditions; very elegant
- Maidenhair Fern (*Adiantum* spp.) — Delicate fan-shaped leaflets on black stems; beautiful but demanding high humidity; challenging
- Staghorn Fern (*Platycerium* spp.) — Grows mounted on wood or in a basket; dramatic; hangs like a living wall piece
- Japanese Painted Fern (*Athyrium niponicum*) — Silver-green fronds with red midribs; one of the most beautiful; needs cool temps
- Button Fern (*Pellaea rotundifolia*) — Small round leaflets; compact; more drought-tolerant than most ferns
- Rabbit's Foot Fern (*Davallia fejeensis*) — Fuzzy silver rhizomes hang over pot edge; unusual and charming
- Sword Fern (*Polystichum munitum*) — Tough, upright; more tolerant of lower humidity
- Silver Lace Fern (*Pteris ensiformis*) — Delicate silver-streaked fronds; compact
- Blue Star Fern (*Phlebodium aureum*) — Waxy blue-green fronds; tolerates low humidity better than most

Orchids (Phalaenopsis, Dendrobium, and others)

Safe for pets. Most spectacular flowering houseplants for indirect light. Blooms last 2–4 months.

Light	Bright indirect; east window is ideal; n
Water	Water weekly (soak roots, then let drain
Temperature	65–80°F days; 55–65°F nights encourage r
Container	Clear plastic pot with drainage inside a
Display	East windowsill, shelf near bright windo
Humidity	Moderate to high; occasional misting acc

Varieties for Apartments

- Phalaenopsis (Moth Orchid) — The standard grocery store orchid. Long-lasting blooms; easiest to care for; huge range of colors and patterns. Reblooms readily in the right conditions.
- Dendrobium — More compact; some need a dry winter rest period to trigger blooming; varied flower colors
- Oncidium (Dancing Lady) — Small, abundant yellow flowers on branching spikes; tolerates more light
- Miltoniopsis (Pansy Orchid) — Large pansy-like flowers; strong fragrance; needs cooler temperatures
- Paphiopedilum (Slipper Orchid) — Tolerates lower light; unique pouch-shaped flowers; no pseudobulbs
- Cattleya — Large, fragrant blooms; needs more light than Phalaenopsis

Reblooming: After the last flower drops, cut the spike back to a node (green bump on the stem). Place in a cooler spot (55–65°F nights) for 4–6 weeks. Then return to regular conditions. A new spike should emerge in 8–12 weeks.

African Violet (Saintpaulia / Streptocarpus ionanthus)

Safe for pets. Flowers prolifically in indirect light. Compact and apartment-friendly.

Light	Bright indirect; east window or filtered
Water	Water from the bottom (fill saucer; let
Temperature	65-80°F
Container	African violet pots (self-watering wick
Display	Windowsill; the self-watering pot makes

Varieties

African violets come in hundreds of cultivars with single, double, and ruffled flowers in white, pink, lavender, purple, red, and bicolor combinations. Notable types:

- Standard — Most common; rosette of fuzzy leaves
- Miniature — Under 6" in diameter; multiple plants can share a small windowsill
- Trailing — Hang over pot edges; good for hanging baskets
- Semi-miniature — Between standard and miniature

Propagation: Snap off a mature leaf with its stem. Insert the petiole (stem) at 45° into moist potting mix. Cover with a clear plastic bag (mini-greenhouse). Small plantlets emerge from the base of the stem in 6-8 weeks.



Peperomia (Peperomia spp.)

Safe for pets. Low-maintenance, drought-tolerant, and available in a remarkable range of leaf shapes and textures.

Light	Bright indirect to moderate
Water	Allow top 2" to dry between waterings; s
Temperature	65–80°F
Container	4–6" (these are generally small plants)
Display	Desk, shelf, grouped collections

Varieties (a sampling — there are over 1,000 species)

- Watermelon Peperomia (*P. argyreia*) — Stunning watermelon stripe pattern; very popular
- String of Turtles (*P. prostrata*) — Tiny turtle-shell patterned leaves on trailing stems; excellent in hanging pots
- Baby Rubber Plant (*P. obtusifolia*) — Thick, glossy, rounded leaves; very tough
- Caperata / Ripple Peperomia (*P. caperata*) — Deep corrugated leaves; compact rosette
- Hope Peperomia (*P. tetraphylla* 'Hope') — Small round succulent-like leaves; trails
- Frost Peperomia (*P. caperata* 'Frost') — Silver sheen over dark leaves; elegant
- Red Log / Columbian Peperomia (*P. metallica*) — Dark metallic red leaves with silver stripe
- Lemon Lime Peperomia (*P. citrinaefolia*) — Vivid yellow-green
- Raindrop Peperomia (*P. polybotrya*) — Large glossy shield-shaped leaves; very dramatic

Hoya / Wax Plant (Hoya spp.)

Safe for pets. Produces waxy, intensely fragrant flower clusters. Slow growing but worth the wait.

Light	Bright indirect; more light = more bloom
Water	Allow top half of soil to dry between wa
Temperature	60–80°F
Container	4–8"; do not overpot — hoyas bloom better
Display	Hanging planter, high shelf, trained aro

Varieties

- Hoya carnosa — Classic wax plant; pink star-shaped flowers with red centers; very fragrant
- Hoya kerrii (Sweetheart Hoya) — Heart-shaped leaves; typically sold as single-leaf cuttings (will not grow into a full plant unless it has a node)
- Hoya pubicalyx — Long trailing vines; deep red or maroon flower clusters
- Hoya australis — Fast-growing; fragrant white flowers
- Hoya linearis — Unusual; soft, fuzzy, thin cylindrical leaves; pendulous; very different look
- Hoya lacunosa — Compact; small leaves; heavily fragrant white flowers
- Hoya obovata — Large round leaves; often with silver speckles
- Hoya wayetii / shepherdii — Long strap-like leaves; trailing

Never remove the peduncle (flower spur) after flowers fall — the plant will bloom from the same spur repeatedly for years.

Bromeliads (Bromeliad family — Aechmea, Guzmania, Vriesea, Tillandsia)

Safe for pets. Dramatic flowering, architectural form, and very low maintenance.

Light	Bright indirect; air plants (Tillandsia)
Water	Fill the central "cup" (rosette center)
Temperature	65-80°F
Container	6-8" for potted bromeliads; no soil need
Display	Shelf, table; air plants on driftwood, w

Varieties

- Aechmea fasciata (Urn Plant) — Silver-banded leaves; pink compound flower head; long-lasting
- Guzmania lingulata — Bright red, orange, or yellow flower bracts; smooth leaves
- Vriesea splendens (Flaming Sword) — Striking red sword-shaped flower stalk
- Neoregelia carolinae (Blushing Bromeliad) — Center turns red/pink at blooming; colorful; compact
- Tillandsia ionantha — Tiny air plant; turns red and produces purple flower when blooming
- Tillandsia xerographica — Large; silvery curling leaves; spectacular
- Tillandsia usneoides (Spanish Moss) — The cascading grey-silver type; grows hanging

After Blooming: The mother plant slowly dies after producing a flower, but generates "pups" (offsets) at the base. Detach pups when they're one-third the size of the mother and pot separately.

Nerve Plant (Fittonia spp.)

Safe for pets. Tiny, low-growing, with intricate vein patterns in white, pink, or red. Perfect for terrariums.

Light	Bright indirect to moderate; no direct s
Water	Keep consistently moist; wilts quickly b
Temperature	65-80°F
Container	Small 4-6" pot; excellent in terrariums
Display	Terrarium, glass dome, tray garden, bath
Humidity	High — a terrarium is the ideal environm

Varieties

- Fittonia albivenis 'White Anne' — White veins on dark green
- Fittonia albivenis 'Frankie' — Pink veins; very popular
- Fittonia albivenis 'Red Anne' — Red-pink veins; vibrant
- Fittonia albivenis 'Skeleton' — Deeply lobed leaves with bold white veins; dramatic

Fittonias are often called "drama plants" for their tendency to completely collapse when dry — only to fully recover within 30 minutes of watering. Despite the theatrics, they are quite forgiving.



Tradescantia / Spiderwort (Tradescantia spp.)

MILDLY TOXIC TO CATS AND DOGS – causes contact dermatitis and GI upset if ingested. The sap can also irritate human skin.

Vigorous, trailing, with some of the most vivid foliage available. Fast-growing and very easy to propagate.

Light	Bright indirect; tolerates moderate; var
Water	Allow top inch to dry between waterings
Temperature	60–80°F
Container	6–8"; excellent in hanging planters
Display	Hanging basket, high shelf, trained down

Varieties

- Tradescantia zebrina (Wandering Jew) – Purple-silver striped; metallic sheen; iconic
- Tradescantia fluminensis – Small, glossy, pure green or cream-variegated
- Tradescantia pallida (Purple Heart) – Deep solid purple; full sun best outdoors; indoor bright indirect acceptable
- Tradescantia sillamontana (White Velvet) – Covered in white hairs; unique texture
- Tradescantia nanouk – Pink, green, and cream striped; compact; very popular
- Tradescantia albiflora 'Albovittata' – Green leaves with cream stripes; rapid grower



Chinese Evergreen (*Aglaonema* spp.)

TOXIC TO CATS AND DOGS — insoluble calcium oxalates cause oral irritation, drooling, and vomiting.

One of the most tolerant houseplants. Thrives in a huge range of light conditions. Colorful and low-maintenance.

Light	Moderate to bright indirect; green varie
Water	Allow top inch to dry between waterings
Temperature	60–80°F; sensitive to cold drafts and te
Container	6–10"
Display	Shelf, table, floor planter for large sp

Varieties

- *Aglaonema commutatum* — Classic silver-green pattern; very low light tolerant
- *Aglaonema* 'Silver Bay' — Large silver-and-green leaves; architectural
- *Aglaonema* 'Red Siam' — Green leaves edged in red; striking
- *Aglaonema* 'Siam Aurora' — Vivid pink-red new growth; needs more light to hold color
- *Aglaonema* 'Emerald Beauty' — Dark green with silver mottling; very tolerant
- *Aglaonema* 'Pink Dalmatian' — Green leaves spotted with hot pink; dramatic
- *Aglaonema* 'Chocolate' — Deep chocolate-brown and green; moody and dramatic
- *Aglaonema* 'Wishes' — Cream, pink, and green; very colorful

Rubber Plant (Ficus elastica)

MILDLY TOXIC TO CATS AND DOGS – milky latex sap causes skin and GI irritation.

Bold, architectural statement plant with large, glossy leaves. Grows into a small indoor tree over time.

Light	Bright indirect; more light preserves va
Water	Allow top 2" to dry between waterings
Temperature	60-80°F
Container	10-14"; eventually needs floor planter
Display	Floor planter, corner accent, architectu

Varieties

- Ficus elastica 'Robusta' – Classic glossy dark green; the hardiest
- Ficus elastica 'Burgundy' – Deep burgundy-black leaves; dramatic
- Ficus elastica 'Tineke' – Green, cream, and pink variegation; elegant
- Ficus elastica 'Ruby' – Pink, cream, and green; striking
- Ficus elastica 'Shivereana' – Cream and green with pink flush; subtle
- Ficus elastica 'Abidjan' – Very dark, almost black foliage

Wipe leaves regularly with a damp cloth to remove dust and maximize light absorption. Rubber plants dislike being moved – find a good spot and leave them.



Dracaena (Dracaena spp. including former Sansevieria)

MILDLY TOXIC TO CATS AND DOGS – saponins cause vomiting, excessive drooling, and weakness.

An enormous genus covering some of the toughest houseplants in existence, from snake plants to corn plants to dragon trees.

Light	Moderate to bright indirect; snake plant
Water	Allow soil to dry completely between wat
Temperature	60–80°F
Container	6–14" depending on variety
Display	Floor planter, shelf, corner, bathroom

Varieties

- Snake Plant / Sansevieria (D. trifasciata) – Stiff upright variegated leaves; nearly indestructible; tolerates deep low light; excellent for beginners and forgotten corners
- Bird of Paradise (D. trifasciata 'Hahnii' - Bird's Nest) – Compact rosette form of snake plant; 6" tall
- Cylindrical Snake Plant (D. cylindrica) – Round pointed leaves; architectural
- Corn Plant (D. fragrans 'Massangeana') – Cane with corn-like leaves; yellow stripe; tolerates very low light
- Dragon Tree (D. marginata) – Thin red-edged leaves on branching canes; architectural
- Colorama Dracaena (D. marginata 'Colorama') – Deep red-pink and white striped
- Song of India / Jamaica (D. reflexa) – Spiraling yellow-and-green or white-and-green leaves
- Lemon Lime Dracaena (D. deremensis 'Lemon Lime') – Bright yellow-green stripes; vivid
- White Stripe Dracaena (D. deremensis 'Warneckii') – Grey-green with white stripes

Pilea (Pilea spp.)

Safe for pets. Fast-growing, easy-to-propagate, includes the beloved Chinese Money Plant.

Light	Bright indirect; rotate regularly for ev
Water	Allow top inch to dry between waterings
Temperature	60-80°F
Container	4-8"
Display	Shelf, table, windowsill

Varieties

- Chinese Money Plant (P. peperomioides) – Circular coin-like leaves on thin stems; produces pups at the base for endless propagation
- Aluminum Plant (P. cadieri) – Silver-splashed leaves; low-growing
- Moon Valley Pilea (P. mollis) – Textured, quilted bronze-green leaves with deep valleys
- Artillery Plant (P. microphylla) – Tiny leaves; shoots pollen explosively when touched
- Silver Sparkle Pilea (P. glauca) – Tiny silver-dusted leaves on trailing stems; excellent in hanging pots

PART B: LOW LIGHT / SHADE

North-facing windows, corners, rooms without strong natural light, or spots more than 6 feet from any window. Direct sun never reaches these plants. Ambient room light and incidental daylight only.

Important reality check: almost no edible plant produces meaningful food in true low light. If you want to grow food, this is the section where a grow light pays for itself.

EDIBLE PLANTS — LOW LIGHT

Mint in Low Light (*Mentha* spp.)

Mint is the only edible herb that can genuinely survive and provide limited harvests in low-light conditions. It will be leggy and less flavorful than a windowsill plant, but it will survive. A north-facing window is better than a windowless corner. Expect slow growth and pale leaves. Harvest sparingly — the plant needs its leaves to photosynthesize with whatever light it gets.

Scallion Regrowth in Water

Cut green onions placed in a glass of water will regrow their tops using stored energy in the roots. This works in near-darkness for 1–3 harvests before the stored energy depletes. It is less about growing and more about extending what you already bought. Change water every 2 days.

DECORATIVE PLANTS — LOW LIGHT

ZZ Plant (Zamioculcas zamiifolia)

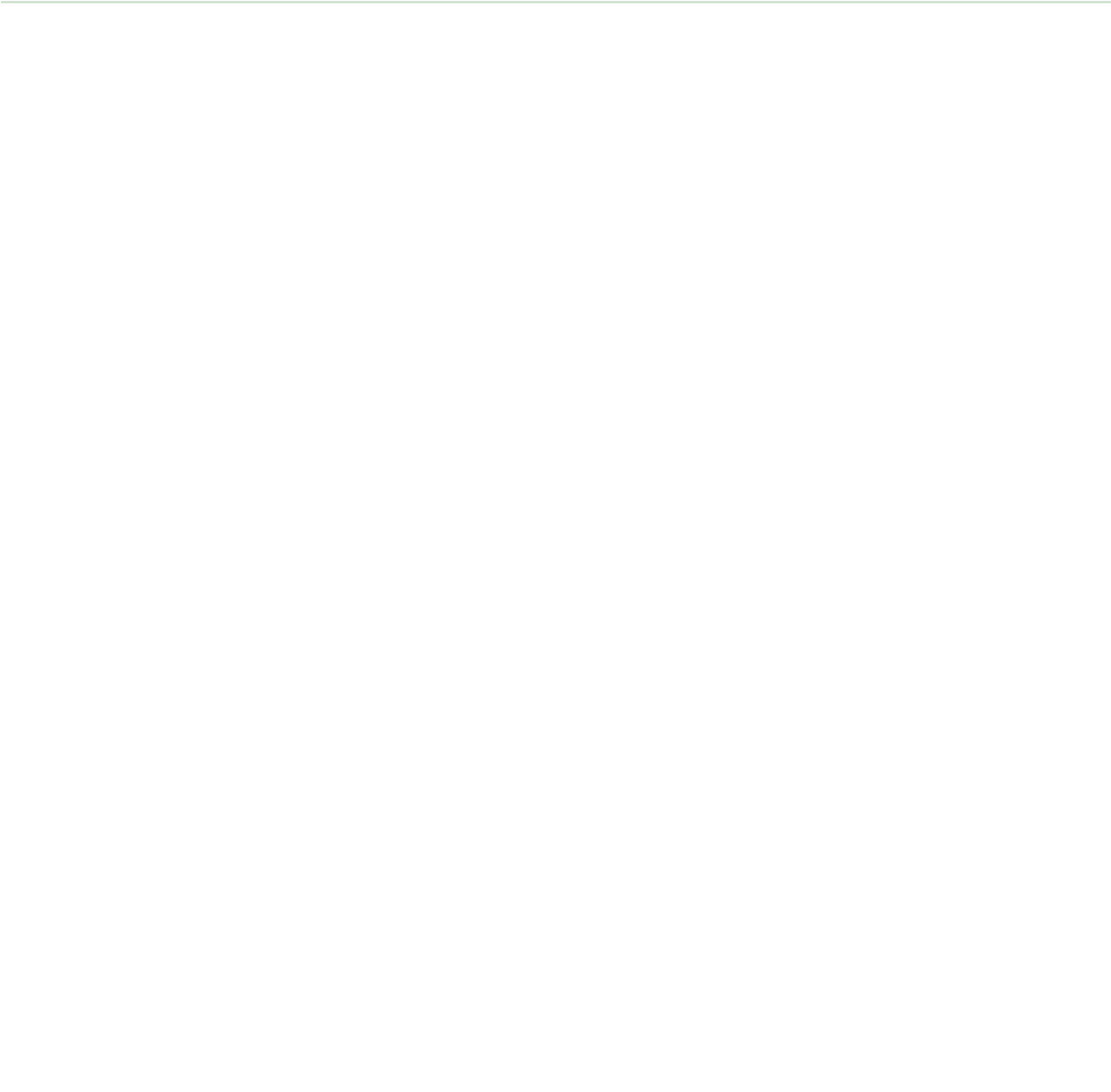
TOXIC TO CATS AND DOGS – all parts contain calcium oxalates; also mildly irritating to human skin (wash hands after handling).

The definitive low-light plant. Thrives on neglect in spaces that would kill anything else.

Light	Low to moderate indirect; tolerates fluo
Water	Allow soil to dry completely before wate
Temperature	60–80°F
Container	6–10"
Display	Dark corners, hallways, bathrooms withou

Varieties

- Standard ZZ (Z. zamiifolia) – Glossy deep green; can reach 3 feet tall
- Raven ZZ (Z. zamiifolia 'Raven') – Jet black mature leaves; new growth emerges lime green; stunning
- Dwarf ZZ / Zamicro (Z. zamifolia 'Zamicro') – Compact; smaller leaves; good for limited spaces
- Lucky Classic – Similar to standard but slightly variegated



Cast Iron Plant (*Aspidistra elatior*)

Safe for pets. Named for its toughness. Survives deep shade, dust, neglect, and temperature extremes.

Light	Low light to shade; one of the most shad
Water	Allow to dry between waterings; drought
Temperature	45–85°F; extremely temperature tolerant
Container	10–14"
Display	Hallway, dark corners, under stairwells

Large, dark green strappy leaves grow slowly but last for decades. Variegated forms exist (cream stripes) but need slightly more light. The cast iron plant was the signature Victorian parlor plant precisely because Victorian parlors had poor light and coal-heated dry air — conditions where it thrives.

Parlor Palm (*Chamaedorea elegans*)

Safe for pets. The most low-light tolerant palm, and one of the most pet-safe houseplants available.

Light	Low to bright indirect
Water	Allow top inch to dry between waterings;
Temperature	60–80°F
Container	8–12"
Display	Corner accent, floor planter, grouped wi

Graceful arching fronds; can grow to 4–6 feet over many years. One of the NASA-listed air-purifying plants. Produces small yellow flowers and berries in maturity. Very slow-growing — a large specimen is an investment worth protecting.

Lucky Bamboo (*Dracaena sanderiana*)

Safe for pets (true bamboo is also safe; lucky bamboo is a *Dracaena* grown to resemble bamboo).

NOTE: True bamboo is a separate plant. Lucky bamboo is *Dracaena sanderiana*. Despite the *Dracaena* classification, it is considered safe for pets by most sources. Verify with your vet if you have sensitive animals.

Light	Low to moderate indirect; tolerates fluo
Water	Grows in water – submerge roots in 1-3"
Temperature	65-80°F
Container	Any waterproof vessel: glass bowl, vase,
Display	Desk, table, shelf

Change water every 1-2 weeks. Yellow leaves indicate too much light, fluoride sensitivity, or overfertilization. Lucky bamboo is traditionally sold in shapes – spirals, braids, towers – created by rotating the plants under directed light as they grow.

Heartleaf Philodendron (*Philodendron hederaceum*)

TOXIC TO CATS AND DOGS (see Philodendron entry in Bright Indirect section).

The heartleaf philodendron is the most low-light tolerant member of the Philodendron genus. It will survive and grow (more slowly) in genuinely dim conditions. Leaves become larger and more widely spaced with less light. Still trailing and elegant. Still dangerous to pets.

Dieffenbachia / Dumb Cane (Dieffenbachia spp.)

HIGHLY TOXIC TO CATS, DOGS, AND HUMANS. Contains insoluble calcium oxalates that cause intense burning and swelling of the mouth, tongue, and throat. Can temporarily cause inability to speak (hence "dumb cane"). Not recommended for homes with children or pets.

Despite its toxicity, Dieffenbachia is listed here because it is extremely common and sold widely. It grows in low light with minimal care. Its beautiful patterned leaves and low maintenance appeal to beginners. The risk is real: if you have cats, dogs, or young children, choose something else.

Varieties: *D. seguine*, *D. maculata*, *D. 'Camille'*, *D. 'Tropic Snow'*, *D. 'Sterling'*.

Prayer Plant (*Maranta leuconeura*)

Safe for pets. See full entry in Bright Indirect — Calathea & Prayer Plants. Tolerates low light but grows more slowly.

Pothos in Low Light

TOXIC TO CATS AND DOGS (see full entry in Bright Indirect section).

Pothos is listed again here because it is genuinely one of the only plants that survives true low light while still growing visibly. Variegation fades in low light (all-green leaves replace the patterned ones), but the plant survives. Still toxic to pets.

SECTION TWO: OUTDOOR PLANTS — BALCONIES AND WINDOW BOXES

The outdoor environment dramatically expands what you can grow. Direct sun, moving air, and space for larger containers make fruiting crops, tall herbs, and full ornamental displays possible. Know your balcony's orientation before buying anything.

PART A: FULL SUN — 6+ HOURS DIRECT SUNLIGHT

South- or west-facing balconies, rooftop gardens, fire escapes with open sky. The sun reaches the plants directly for at least 6 hours per day. These conditions are equivalent to a garden bed.

VEGETABLES — FULL SUN OUTDOOR

Cherry and Patio Tomatoes (*Solanum lycopersicum*)

The most productive edible for a sunny balcony. Cherry varieties are unbeatable.

Light	Full sun — 8+ hours optimal
Water	Consistent and deep; do not let dry out
Temperature	65–85°F; no frost; slow below 55°F
Container	Minimum 5 gallons (10–15 gallon preferred)
Support	Cage, stake, or trellis attached to balc
Display	Balcony railing, floor containers, grow

Best Varieties for Containers

- Tumbling Tom Red / Yellow — Bred for hanging baskets; cascades over the edge; prolific
- Tiny Tim — Truly compact at 12–18"; can grow in a 1-gallon pot
- Sun Gold — The gold standard cherry tomato; orange, incredibly sweet; vigorous (use a 10-gal minimum)
- Black Cherry — Deep burgundy-red; complex, rich flavor
- Sweet Million — Reliable, heavy-bearing; excellent disease resistance
- Juliet — Elongated plum-cherry; crack resistant; prolific
- Yellow Pear — Novelty tear-drop shape; prolific; mild flavor
- Bush Early Girl — Compact determinate; full-size tomatoes on a 2-foot plant
- Patio (V.F.N.T.) — Determinate; bred specifically for containers; 18–24" plant
- Tumbler — Semi-determinate; good for hanging baskets

Detailed Care

Tomatoes are water-hungry — a 10-gallon container on a hot balcony may need daily watering in summer. Install self-watering reservoirs or drip irrigation on a timer to manage this. Feed weekly with a tomato-specific fertilizer (high potassium) once flowers appear.

Remove suckers (stems that emerge in the V between main stem and branch) on indeterminate varieties to manage size. Determinate varieties do not need this.

Container Size Matters: A 5-gallon container will produce a plant; a 15-gallon container will produce a harvest. Do not cut corners on container size for tomatoes.

Peppers (*Capsicum annuum* and related species)

More container-friendly than tomatoes. A single plant can produce 20–50 fruits in a season.

Light	Full sun
Water	Consistent moisture; more drought-tolera
Temperature	70–90°F; no frost; loves heat
Container	5–10 gallons depending on variety
Support	Light stake for heavy-bearing plants
Display	Balcony floor, railing boxes

Sweet Peppers

- Sweet Banana — Long yellow fruits; prolific; compact plant
- Carmen — Sweet Italian frying pepper; compact
- Gypsy — Early, prolific, compact; excellent container pepper
- Mini Bell Mix — Very small colorful bells; decorative and productive

Hot Peppers (for the spice enthusiast)

- Jalapeño 'Mucho Nacho' — Large jalapeños; prolific; 2–3 gallon container ok
- Shishito — Japanese wrinkled pepper; 1 in 10 is hot; great grilled; prolific
- Lemon Drop — Bright yellow; fruity heat; Peruvian aji variety
- Cayenne — Prolific; long thin fruits; dry easily; 3-gallon minimum
- Thai Hot / Bird's Eye (*C. annuum* var. *glabriusculum*) — Tiny; extremely hot; prolific; compact plant
- Habanero — Orange; 200,000+ Scoville; compact plant; high yield
- Serrano — More compact than jalapeño; hotter; prolific
- Rocoto (*C. pubescens*) — Round fuzzy fruits; apple-like; very different flavor; cool-weather tolerant
- Fish Pepper — Heirloom African-American variety; variegated leaves; unique
- NuMex Twilight — Ornamental and edible; purple-yellow-red fruits; compact; excellent container variety
- Tabasco (*C. frutescens*) — The original hot sauce pepper; upright-pointing fruits; prolific

Eggplant (Solanum melongena)

Heat-loving, stunning to look at, and productive in containers. A forgotten balcony vegetable.

Light	Full sun
Water	Consistent moisture
Temperature	70–90°F; heat-loving
Container	5–10 gallons
Display	Balcony floor or large railing container

Varieties

- Fairy Tale — Small oval purple-and-white striped fruits; very prolific; compact (18–24"); ideal for containers
 - Hansel — Long slender purple fruits; prolific; AAS winner; very compact
 - Gretel — White version of Hansel; compact; prolific; mild flavor
 - Ichiban — Long Japanese-style eggplant; slender; 3–4 foot plant; excellent flavor
 - Little Prince (F1) — Extra compact; 12" fruits on a 2-foot plant
 - Rosa Bianca — Lavender-cream heirloom; round; mild and creamy; beautiful
 - Orient Charm — Small elongated; prolific; compact
-

Cucumbers (Cucumis sativus)

Fast-growing, prolific, and perfectly suited to a trellis against a balcony railing or wall.

Light	Full sun
Water	Consistent and deep; irregular watering
Temperature	70–90°F
Container	5+ gallons; long window box for multiple
Support	Trellis, string lattice, netting — cucum
Display	Trellis against balcony wall; vertical g

Best Container Varieties

- Bush Pickle — Compact 18–24" plant; pickling-sized fruits; prolific
- Spacemaster — Compact; 3-foot vines; slicing cucumbers
- Bush Champion — Full-size slicers on a compact bush
- Picklebush — Very compact; excellent picklers; 8" fruits
- Patio Snacker — Baby cucumbers; very compact; no trellis needed
- Salad Bush — AAS winner; compact; slicers on 24" plants
- Miniature White — Small white cucumbers; compact; unusual and beautiful

Trellising: Attach mesh, twine, or a cattle panel section to your balcony wall or railing. Train vines up as they grow — they grab on with tendrils. This saves enormous floor space and improves airflow, reducing disease.

Bush Beans (*Phaseolus vulgaris*)

Low-maintenance, nitrogen-fixing, and productive with no support needed.

Light	Full sun
Water	Moderate; water at the base (avoid wetti
Temperature	60–85°F
Container	12"+ pot or window box; minimum 8" deep
Display	Window box, floor container

Varieties

- Blue Lake 274 – Classic green bean; straight pods; very productive
- Provider – Early and dependable; tolerates cooler soil; disease resistant
- Dragon Tongue – Yellow with purple stripes; distinctive; harvested young
- Contender – Very early; heat and drought tolerant
- Roma II – Italian flat pod; excellent flavor; prolific
- Royal Burgundy – Purple pods (turn green when cooked); ornamental and edible
- Rattlesnake Pole Bean – Technically a pole bean (needs trellis) but spectacular purple-streaked pods

Direct seed into containers; beans hate transplanting. Harvest daily once pods reach full size – the plant keeps producing as long as you keep harvesting.



Peas (Pisum sativum)

A cool-season crop for early spring and fall. Among the fastest and most rewarding container vegetables.

Light	Full sun to partial shade
Water	Keep consistently moist
Temperature	45–70°F; tolerates light frost; bolts in
Container	Window box or deep container; at least 8
Support	Trellis or netting (most varieties)
Display	Trellis on balcony; cascading over raili

Varieties

- Sugar Ann — Dwarf snap pea; 18–24" tall; no trellis needed; AAS winner
- Little Marvel — Compact shelling pea; good in containers
- Tom Thumb — Dwarf; 8–9" tall; produces full-size pods; ideal for very small spaces
- Mammoth Melting Sugar — Snow pea; tall (4–5 feet); needs trellis; flat edible pods
- Oregon Sugar Pod II — Snow pea; compact; disease resistant
- Super Sugar Snap — Tall snap pea; needs trellis; exceptional flavor
- Dwarf Grey Sugar — Edible flower + edible pod; compact; heirloom

Sow peas as soon as soil can be worked (or as soon as daytime temps consistently hit 45°F+). They will stop producing when temperatures exceed 80°F.

Zucchini and Summer Squash (Cucurbita pepo)

Warning: zucchini will take over your balcony if you let it. Choose compact varieties and commit to regular harvesting.

Light	Full sun
Water	Deep and consistent; large leaves transp
Temperature	65-90°F
Container	Minimum 10 gallons; larger is better
Display	Large floor container
Notes	Needs hand pollination if no bees visit

Compact Varieties

- Patio Star (F1) — True compact habit; bred for containers; productive
- Bush Baby — Compact; good in 10-gallon containers
- Astia — Bred specifically for pots; compact
- Magda — Club-shaped; pale green; compact; Middle Eastern type
- Tromboncino — Italian climbing squash; can be trellised vertically

Harvest zucchini at 6-8 inches — do not let them become marrows, which drains the plant's energy. A single plant can produce a dozen fruits per week at peak.



Radishes (*Raphanus sativus*)

The fastest vegetable in the garden. Ready in 25–30 days from seed. Perfect for filling gaps between other plantings.

Light	Full sun to partial shade
Water	Keep consistently moist
Temperature	45–65°F; bolts quickly in heat
Container	Any 6"+ pot; minimum 6" deep for most va
Display	Window box, any available container

Varieties

- Cherry Belle — Round red; classic; 22 days
- French Breakfast — Elongated; mild; 25 days
- Watermelon — White outside, vivid magenta inside; 50–60 days; slice for salads
- Easter Egg Mix — Round; mix of red, pink, white, and purple; 25 days
- Daikon — Long white radish; needs deeper container (12"+); 60 days
- Black Spanish Round — Black skin, white flesh; peppery; 55 days
- Rat's Tail Radish — Grown for edible pods (not roots); excellent container crop

Carrots (*Daucus carota* subsp. *sativus*)

Container carrots require specific short or round varieties and a deep container. Get the container right and they're effortless.

Light	Full sun
Water	Keep moist; irregular watering causes sp
Temperature	55–75°F; best in cool-to-warm weather
Container	Deep: at least 12" for short varieties,
Display	Deep planters, large floor containers

Best Container Varieties

- Parisian (Parisienne) — Round, 1–2" diameter; bred for shallow containers; harvest in 60–70 days
- Chantenay Red Core — Broad, stocky, 5–7" long; needs 12" depth; excellent flavor
- Danvers 126 — Shorter, blocky; good in containers
- Thumbelina — Nearly round like Parisian; AAS winner; very sweet
- Little Finger — Miniature Nantes type; 3–4" long; sweet
- Oxheart — Wide, stumpy; 4–5" long, 3–4" wide; stores well
- Atlas — Round; great flavor; works in 8–10" pots

Direct seed thinly; carrots do not transplant. Thin to 2" spacing when 2" tall. Flavor improves after frost exposure.

Beets (Beta vulgaris)

Double crop: edible root AND highly nutritious greens. Faster than most root vegetables.

Light	Full sun
Water	Keep consistently moist
Temperature	50-75°F
Container	At least 10-12" deep; wide containers fo
Display	Large floor container or window box

Varieties

- Detroit Dark Red – Classic; 2-3" roots; 55 days; reliable
- Chioggia – Candy-cane interior; red and white rings; sweet; heirloom
- Bull's Blood – Deep maroon leaves and roots; grown as much for its dramatic foliage as the root; ornamental AND edible
- Golden – Yellow-orange; sweet; does not bleed; beautiful sliced
- Cylindra – Long cylindrical root; easier to slice uniformly
- White Albino – Mild, sweet, ivory flesh; unusual; no beet staining
- Crosby Egyptian – Compact root; excellent greens; heirloom

Beet "seeds" are actually seed clusters – thin after germination to 3-4" apart. Eat thinnings as baby greens.

Asian Greens (Various species)

Fast-growing, shade-tolerant, and productive in cool seasons. Excellent in window boxes.

Light	Full sun to partial shade (prefer some s
Water	Keep consistently moist
Temperature	45–70°F; bolt in heat
Container	Window box, shallow trays, 8" pots
Display	Window box, railing planter

Varieties

- Bok Choy (Pak Choi) (*Brassica rapa* subsp. *chinensis*) — Fast; mild; harvest whole at 4–6 weeks or individual leaves
- Tatsoi (*B. rapa* var. *narinosa*) — Dark rosettes; spoon-shaped leaves; mild; bolts slower than bok choy
- Mizuna (*B. rapa* var. *nipposinica*) — Deeply lobed, feathery leaves; mild-peppery; very fast
- Komatsuna (*B. rapa* var. *perviridis*) — Like spinach-mustard; extremely cold hardy; prolific
- Red Giant Mustard (*B. juncea*) — Massive purple-red leaves; pungent; ornamental and edible
- Choy Sum (*B. rapa* var. *parachinensis*) — Harvested in flower bud stage; sweet; prolific
- Napa Cabbage — Compact varieties possible in 5+ gallon containers
- Chinese Broccoli / Gai Lan (*B. oleracea* var. *alboglabra*) — Harvest young shoots; bitter-sweet; versatile

HERBS — FULL SUN OUTDOOR

Basil (*Ocimum basilicum*)

The defining summer balcony herb. Full sun unlocks its full flavor potential.

Light	Full sun — 6+ hours
Water	Keep consistently moist
Temperature	65–90°F; no frost
Container	6–10" pot; can be planted densely in win
Display	Window box, balcony table, railing plant

Varieties

- Sweet Basil — The standard; Genovese is the classic pesto variety
- Genovese — Large leaves; intensely aromatic; the best for pesto
- Superbo — Extra large leaves; excellent pesto
- Thai Basil (*O. basilicum* var. *thyrsiflora*) — Anise-flavored; purple stems; holds flavor when cooked
- Purple/Dark Opal — Deep purple; visually stunning; vinegars, salads
- Lemon (*O. × citriodorum*) — Citrus-forward; excellent in fish, cocktails
- Lime (*O. americanum*) — Lime-scented; smaller leaves; Southeast Asian dishes
- Cinnamon (*O. basilicum* 'Cinnamon') — Spicy-sweet; Mexican and Southeast Asian cooking
- African Blue — Sterile hybrid; continuous production without bolting; highly aromatic; excellent pollinators
- Spicy Globe — Tiny leaves; perfect sphere shape; ornamental and edible
- Cardinal — Purple flower spikes; ornamental; good flavor
- Holy Basil / Tulsi (*O. tenuiflorum*) — Sacred in Hinduism; peppery-clove flavor; used in Thai cooking and medicinal tea

Rosemary (*Salvia rosmarinus*, formerly *Rosmarinus officinalis*)

A woody Mediterranean shrub that thrives in hot, dry balcony conditions. Gets better with age.

Light	Full sun
Water	Allow to dry between waterings; drought
Temperature	55-90°F; some varieties tolerate frost
Container	12-16" pot with excellent drainage
Display	Large balcony container; architectural a

Varieties

- Tuscan Blue – Upright; vigorous; excellent flavor; large leaves
- Arp – Hardy; survives light frosts; excellent for cold balconies
- Prostrate/Trailing (*S. rosmarinus* Prostratus Group) – Cascading habit; excellent over walls or edges; not frost-hardy
- Gorizia – Very large leaves; mild flavor; ornamental
- Barbecue – Stiff stems; used as skewers; functional
- Spice Islands – Compact; intense flavor

Rosemary is slow to establish but will eventually become a large, productive shrub. Prune after flowering to maintain shape. Do not overwater – it rots quickly in wet conditions.

Thyme (Thymus spp.)

Compact, drought-tolerant, and perfect for edging containers. Also a beautiful ground cover in large planters.

Light	Full sun
Water	Allow to dry between waterings
Temperature	50–80°F; frost hardy
Container	6–10" pot; excellent in shallow wide con
Display	Edge of large planters, window box fille

Varieties

- Common Thyme (T. vulgaris) – The culinary standard; earthy, warm, versatile
- English Thyme – More compact than common; slightly milder
- Lemon Thyme (T. × citriodorus) – Bright lemon scent; excellent in fish, chicken, desserts; variegated forms available
- Creeping Thyme (T. serpyllum) – Low ground-covering mat; tolerates foot traffic; good in large shallow containers
- Caraway Thyme (T. herba-barona) – Caraway-thyme flavor; low growing
- Orange Thyme (T. 'Fragrantissimus') – Orange-citrus scent; unusual; culinary and ornamental
- Woolly Thyme (T. pseudolanuginosus) – Fuzzy silver-grey; primarily ornamental but edible; beautiful texture

Oregano (Origanum spp.)

One of the easiest herbs. Thrives on hot sun and poor soil. Flavor intensifies when stressed.

Light	Full sun
Water	Allow to dry between waterings; drought
Temperature	55–90°F; frost hardy once established
Container	8–10" pot
Display	Window box, standalone pot, trailing ove

Varieties

- Greek Oregano (O. vulgare subsp. hirtum) — The most flavorful; intensely aromatic; white flowers
 - Italian Oregano (O. × majoricum) — Milder than Greek; more culinary versatility
 - Hot and Spicy Oregano — Intense heat on the finish
 - Marjoram (O. majorana) — Milder, sweeter cousin; excellent in sausage, stuffing, egg dishes
 - Mexican Oregano (Lippia graveolens) — Completely different plant; citrus and pepper notes; essential in Mexican cooking
 - Syrian Oregano (O. syriacum) — Za'atar ingredient; milder; used in Middle Eastern cooking
 - Hopley's Purple — Decorative; intense flavor; vibrant purple flowers
-

Sage (*Salvia officinalis*)

Robust and ornamental. Beautiful purple flowers in spring. Essential for holiday cooking and compound butter.

Light	Full sun
Water	Allow to dry between waterings
Temperature	50–80°F; frost hardy
Container	10–12" pot
Display	Container herb garden, ornamental-edible

Varieties

- Common Sage — Large grey-green leaves; strong flavor; reliable
 - Purple Sage (*S. officinalis* 'Purpurascens') — Deep purple new growth; ornamental; good flavor
 - Tricolor Sage (*S. officinalis* 'Tricolor') — White, pink, and green variegation; stunning; milder flavor
 - Golden Sage (*S. officinalis* 'Aurea') — Yellow and green; compact; ornamental
 - Berggarten — Broader, rounded leaves; excellent flavor; compact
 - Pineapple Sage (*S. elegans*) — Bright fruity aroma; red flowers loved by hummingbirds; use fresh in fruit salads, tea, and desserts; not frost hardy
-

Lavender (Lavandula spp.)

MILDLY TOXIC TO CATS AND DOGS – essential oils cause GI upset if ingested in quantity. Dried lavender is generally considered safe; monitor if pets chew on plants.

Fragrant, pollinator-attracting, and long-blooming. One of the most beautiful balcony plants.

Light	Full sun; 8+ hours preferred
Water	Allow to dry completely between watering
Temperature	50–85°F; hardiness varies by species
Container	12–16" pot with exceptional drainage; ad
Display	Standalone container, large mixed plante

Varieties

- English Lavender (L. angustifolia) – Most fragrant; most cold-hardy; small; excellent for culinary use, sachets, essential oils
- Hidcote (L. angustifolia 'Hidcote') – Compact; deep violet; prolific bloomer
- Munstead (L. angustifolia 'Munstead') – Compact; slightly earlier-blooming; classic
- French Lavender (L. dentata) – Toothed leaves; longer bloom period; less hardy
- Spanish Lavender (L. stoechas) – "Rabbit ears" flowers; vigorous; not as fragrant; less cold-hardy
- Phenomenal – Disease-resistant; tolerates humidity better than most; good for humid climates
- Grosso – Tall; high oil content; commercial fragrance variety

Lemongrass (*Cymbopogon citratus*)

A striking ornamental grass with intense lemon-citrus fragrance and flavor. Essential in Southeast Asian cooking.

Light	Full sun
Water	Keep moist during active growth
Temperature	65–90°F; tropical; does not tolerate fro
Container	12–16" pot
Display	Large floor container; architectural acc

Harvest the lower stalks by cutting at soil level. Remove the tough outer layers. Use the tender white inner stalk in curries, soups, marinades, and tea. Lemongrass grows into a tall clump (3–5 feet) by end of summer. Divide and bring indoors for winter in cold climates.

FRUITS — FULL SUN OUTDOOR

Strawberries (*Fragaria × ananassa* and *F. vesca*)

The most productive fruit for containers. Everbearing varieties produce continuously from spring to frost.

Light	Full sun; minimum 6 hours
Water	Keep consistently moist; do not let dry
Temperature	60–80°F; some frost tolerance
Container	Strawberry planter, hanging basket, wind
Display	Hanging basket (runners cascade beautifu

Everbearing / Day-Neutral Varieties (best for containers)

- Seascape — Prolific; large berries; exceptional flavor; excellent container performance
- Albion — Large; firm; sweet; continuous production
- Quinault — Very prolific; soft fruit; good flavor; tolerate partial shade better than most
- Ozark Beauty — Older everbearing variety; excellent flavor; cold-hardy

June-Bearing (heavy one-time harvest)

- Earliglow — Very early; exceptional flavor; excellent for pots
- Honeoye — Consistent; good flavor

Alpine Strawberries / Wild Strawberry **(F. vesca)**

- Alexandria — No runners; tiny intensely-flavored berries; continuous production; tolerates more shade than garden strawberries
 - Mignonette — Small plants; prolific; excellent for window boxes
 - White Soul — Rare white fruits; birds don't recognize them as ripe; highly productive
 - Yellow Wonder — Yellow fruits; unusual; good flavor
-

Dwarf Blueberries (Vaccinium spp.)

The most apartment-friendly berry bush. Ornamental in every season. Berries, fall color, and spring flowers.

Light	Full sun
Water	Keep consistently moist; acidic water pr
Temperature	Varies by variety; most hardy in zones 4
Container	10–15 gallons; acid-specific potting mix
Display	Large floor container
Soil pH	4.5–5.5 — add sulfur or use acid potting
Pollination	Most produce better with two plants; som

Best Compact Varieties

- Top Hat — True dwarf at 18–24"; excellent for containers; self-fertile; good flavor
- Sunshine Blue — Semi-dwarf 3–4'; self-fertile; long harvest window; heat tolerant
- Northblue — Semi-dwarf; cold-hardy (Zone 3); excellent flavor; dark berries
- Peach Sorbet — Very compact; bred for containers; ornamental pink-peach foliage; self-fertile
- Jelly Bean — Very compact; sweet; continuous production; excellent container performance
- Pink Icing — Blue berries on pink-tipped new growth; ornamental; self-fertile
- Bushel and Berry Blueberry Burst — Compact; good flavor; ornamental

Meyer Lemon (Citrus × meyeri)

The most practical citrus for apartment growing. Fragrant flowers, ornamental fruit, and genuine edible harvest.

Light	Full sun — 8+ hours
Water	Allow top inch to dry between waterings;
Temperature	55–90°F outdoors; bring indoors when bel
Container	Minimum 10–15 gallons; larger = more fru
Display	Large floor container; must be moved ind

Meyer lemon is a cross between a true lemon and a mandarin orange — the fruit is rounder, thinner-skinned, and sweeter than grocery store lemons. Year-round flowering means your balcony smells extraordinary whenever the tree blooms.

Other Container Citrus

- Calamondin Orange (× Citrofortunella microcarpa) — Very compact; heavy-bearing small orange fruits; very sour; excellent for marmalade and cocktails; the most apartment-suitable citrus
- Key Lime (Citrus aurantiifolia) — Small; more cold-sensitive; prolific fruits; essential for key lime pie
- Kumquat (Fortunella spp.) — Eat the whole fruit, skin and all; sweet skin, tart flesh; compact; cold-tolerant

Fig (*Ficus carica*)

An ancient fruit, rewarding in containers, and surprisingly productive in small spaces.

Light	Full sun
Water	Moderate; allow top inch to dry; drought
Temperature	50–90°F; some varieties cold-hardy to zo
Container	15–25 gallon; larger = more fruit
Display	Large floor container

Compact Varieties

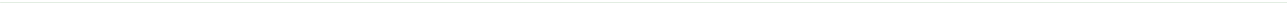
- Little Miss Figgy — True dwarf; 4–5 feet; prolific two-crop producer; good in containers
 - Petite Negra — Very compact; black skin; sweet purple flesh; self-fertile
 - Violette de Bordeaux — Small plant; very sweet dark figs; excellent
 - Brown Turkey — Large; vigorous; very productive; cold-hardy
 - Chicago Hardy — Most cold-hardy variety; can stay outdoors in zone 5 with protection
 - Celeste — Small, sweet fruit; excellent flavor; cold-tolerant
-

Ground Cherries (*Physalis pruinosa*)

Hidden gems. Wrapped in a papery husk; taste like pineapple-vanilla. Extremely prolific and underappreciated.

Light	Full sun
Water	Moderate; drought tolerant once establis
Temperature	65–85°F
Container	5–7 gallon pot
Display	Floor container

Fruits fall from the plant when ripe (still in their husks). They store at room temperature for weeks inside the husks. Use in jam, pie, fresh salsa, dried as candy, or just eat fresh. Plants are large (2–3 feet wide) – give them room. Self-pollinating. Extremely prolific once established.



ORNAMENTALS — FULL SUN OUTDOOR

Geraniums / Pelargoniums (Pelargonium spp.)

TOXIC TO CATS AND DOGS — geraniol and linalool cause vomiting, weakness, and skin irritation.

The quintessential balcony flower. Heat-tolerant, long-blooming, and available in almost every color.

Light	Full sun to bright indirect
Water	Allow to dry between waterings; drought
Temperature	55–85°F; bring indoors before frost
Container	8–12" pot; excellent in window boxes
Display	Window box, railing planter, hanging bas

Types

- Zonal Geraniums (P. × hortorum) — The classic window box geranium; horse-shoe marking on leaves; huge color range
 - Ivy Geraniums (P. peltatum) — Trailing habit; excellent in hanging baskets
 - Regal/Martha Washington Geraniums (P. × domesticum) — Larger flowers; cooler preferences; spring-blooming
 - Scented Geraniums (P. spp.) — Grown for fragrant leaves: Rose, Lemon, Mint, Apple, Coconut, Nutmeg, Ginger scents. Leaves used in cooking, potpourri, and scented sugar
-

Petunias (*Petunia × hybrida*)

Safe for pets. The most prolific and colorful summer flowering annual for containers. Extremely low-maintenance.

Light	Full sun
Water	Regular; do not allow to dry completely
Temperature	55–90°F
Container	8–12" pot, hanging basket, window box
Display	Hanging basket, window box, railing plan

Types

- Grandiflora — Very large flowers; fewer but showier; less rain-tolerant
- Multiflora — Smaller but more numerous flowers; more weather-resistant
- Wave/Spreading — Ground cover and cascading habit; excellent in hanging baskets
- Supertunia — Non-stop self-cleaning bloomer; excellent for containers
- Million Bells (*Calibrachoa*) — Technically a separate genus but sold with petunias; tiny flowers; trailing; extremely prolific; no deadheading needed

Fertilize heavily and regularly (weekly) — petunias are heavy feeders. Deadhead or use self-cleaning varieties.

Marigolds (*Tagetes* spp.)

Safe for pets. Edible flowers, pest deterrent, and prolific bloomer all in one.

Light	Full sun
Water	Moderate; drought tolerant
Temperature	60–90°F
Container	6–10" pot, window box
Display	Edge of vegetable containers (companion

Types

- African Marigold (*T. erecta*) — Large pom-pom flowers; 2–3 feet tall; excellent cut flower; edible petals
- French Marigold (*T. patula*) — Compact; bicolor; very prolific; best for container edges and pest control
- Signet Marigold (*T. tenuifolia*) — Tiny single flowers; ferny foliage; edible flowers with citrus flavor; excellent in food

Marigolds are companion plants — their root secretions deter certain nematodes and pests. Interplant with tomatoes, peppers, and other vegetables. Petals are edible and excellent in salads, rice, eggs, and as a natural food dye.



Zinnias (Zinnia spp.)

Safe for pets. Cut-and-come-again flowers that produce more the more you harvest.

Light	Full sun
Water	Moderate; drought tolerant once establis
Temperature	65-90°F
Container	10-12" pot
Display	Standalone container; excellent for cut

Types

- Zinnia elegans — The classic; huge range of sizes and colors
- Profusion series — Compact; disease-resistant; prolific; AAS winner
- Zahara series — Very compact; mildew-resistant; excellent for containers
- Benary's Giant series — Large flowers; prolific; best for cutting



Sunflowers — Dwarf Varieties (*Helianthus annuus*)

Safe for pets. Edible seeds, edible petals, and spectacular visual impact in a pot.

Light	Full sun
Water	Deep and regular; drought tolerant once
Temperature	65-90°F
Container	5-10 gallons depending on variety
Display	Large standalone container; accent plant

Compact Varieties

- Teddy Bear — Double golden flowers; 2-3 feet; very fluffy
 - Little Becka — Bicolor red-orange; 2 feet; branching; prolific
 - Sunfinity (F1) — Branching; produces flowers continuously all season; exceptional for containers
 - Sunspot — Standard sunflower head on a 2-foot plant; good for small balconies
 - Elf — Only 16" tall; single flowers; the most compact option
-

Cosmos (Cosmos bipinnatus)

Safe for pets. Airy, ferny foliage with cheerful daisy-like flowers. One of the most effortless summer annuals.

Light	Full sun
Water	Drought tolerant; do not overwater or ov
Temperature	65-90°F
Container	10-12" pot
Display	Standalone planter; accent among other c

Cosmos actually perform better in less-fertile soil – too much fertilizer produces lush foliage and few flowers. Direct seed into containers; they dislike transplanting. Deadhead regularly to extend blooming. Edible flowers are mildly sweet.

Morning Glory (Ipomoea purpurea)

SEEDS TOXIC TO CATS, DOGS, AND HUMANS – Morning glory seeds contain lysergic acid amides (related to LSD); can cause hallucinations, GI distress, and other symptoms if ingested. Keep away from children and pets.

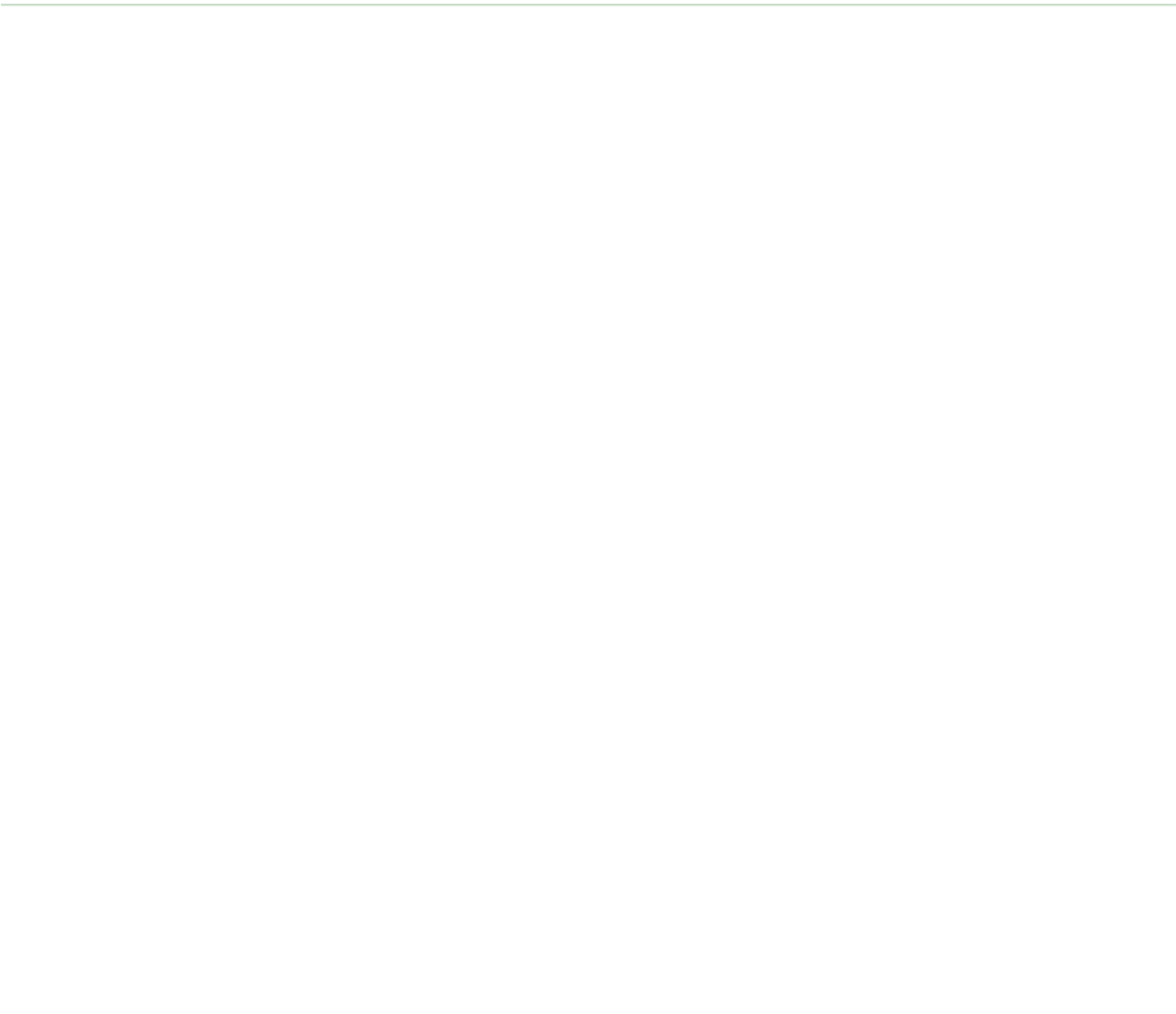
Fast-growing climber that covers a trellis in weeks. Flowers open in the morning and close by afternoon.

Light	Full sun
Water	Moderate
Temperature	65–90°F
Container	5–7 gallon; requires trellis
Display	Trellis against balcony wall; vertical a

Varieties

- Heavenly Blue – The classic; sky-blue flowers
- Grandpa Ott – Deep purple with star center; heirloom
- Flying Saucers – Bicolor blue-and-white stripes
- Scarlett O'Hara – Vivid crimson
- Moonflower (I. alba) – White; opens at night; fragrant; excellent for evening balconies

Soak seeds overnight before planting to improve germination.



Mandevilla (Mandevilla spp.)

MILDLY TOXIC TO CATS AND DOGS – may cause GI irritation if ingested.

Tropical climbing vine with enormous trumpet flowers. The most dramatic balcony vertical plant.

Light	Full sun
Water	Keep moist during active growth
Temperature	65–90°F; tropical; bring indoors before
Container	10–14" pot with sturdy trellis
Display	Trellis on balcony wall; vertical focal

Varieties

- Sun Parasol Crimson – Large deep red flowers; vigorous
- Alice Dupont – Bright pink; classic variety
- White Fantasy – Pure white; very clean and elegant
- Red Riding Hood – Compact; good for smaller spaces

PART B: PARTIAL / INDIRECT SUN OUTDOOR

East-facing balconies, shaded west-facing balconies, north-facing balconies with reflected light, or balconies shaded by overhangs or adjacent buildings. 2–5 hours of direct sun, or bright reflected/ambient light.

EDIBLE PLANTS — PARTIAL SUN OUTDOOR

Lettuce (Outdoor Partial Shade) (*Lactuca sativa*)

Partial shade is actually BETTER for outdoor lettuce in summer — it prevents bolting. Use the same varieties as the indoor section.

Light	2–4 hours direct sun or bright indirect
Water	Keep consistently moist
Temperature	45–70°F optimal; partial shade extends t
Container	Shallow window box; any 6"+ pot
Display	Window box, railing planter

In summer heat, lettuce grown in partial shade lasts 3–4 weeks longer before bolting than the same variety in full sun. An east-facing balcony that gets morning sun but afternoon shade is nearly ideal for a continuous lettuce harvest.

Spinach, Arugula, Asian Greens (Partial Shade Outdoor)

See individual entries in the Full Sun section. All of these prefer partial shade in summer — they tolerate full sun only in spring and fall. An east or north-facing balcony grows better summer greens than a blazing south-facing one.

Herbs (Partial Shade Outdoor)

Herbs that grow well in 3–5 hours of direct sun or bright indirect light:

- Mint (*Mentha* spp.) — Prefers partial shade in hot summers; see full entry
- Parsley (*Petroselinum crispum*) — Tolerates and benefits from afternoon shade
- Cilantro (*Coriandrum sativum*) — Partial shade dramatically delays bolting
- Chives (*Allium schoenoprasum*) — Tolerates partial shade well
- Chervil (*Anthriscus cerefolium*) — Prefers partial shade
- Lemon Balm (*Melissa officinalis*) — Tolerates partial shade
- Sorrel (*Rumex acetosa*) — Excellent in partial shade; bolts more slowly

Note on Cilantro:

Cilantro is the herb most improved by partial shade outdoors. It bolts (flowers and goes to seed) extremely quickly in full sun and heat. An east-facing balcony with morning sun and afternoon shade, combined with consistent moisture, will give you 3–4 weeks more leaf production than full sun. Once it bolts, the seeds (coriander) are also edible and worth harvesting.

Strawberries (Partial Shade Outdoor)

Strawberries produce best with 6+ hours of sun, but everbearing types (especially alpine strawberries) will produce in 4 hours of direct sun. Yields will be lower and fruit ripening slower, but still worthwhile. Alpine strawberries (*F. vesca*) are the best choice for shadier balconies.

ORNAMENTALS — PARTIAL SUN OUTDOOR

Fuchsia (Fuchsia × hybrida)

Safe for pets and edible — the berries are mildly sweet and edible. The most spectacular partial-shade balcony plant.

Light	Partial shade; dappled or morning sun; a
Water	Keep consistently moist; wilt quickly in
Temperature	55–75°F; does not like heat above 80°F
Container	8–12" hanging basket or pot
Display	Hanging basket; the cascading flowers ar

The pendulous bicolor flowers — deep pink, red, white, and purple combinations — cascade from the plant in masses. Trailing varieties are best for hanging baskets; upright varieties work in pots. Fuchsia is one of the few ornamentals that actually prefers shade. The berries that follow flowers are edible — mildly sweet, faintly earthy. Not commercially significant but a fun surprise.

Impatiens (Impatiens walleriana)

Safe for pets. The single most popular bedding plant for shade. Flowers continuously from planting to frost.

Light	Partial to full shade; does not tolerate
Water	Keep consistently moist; wilts in drought
Temperature	60–85°F
Container	8–12" pot, window box, hanging basket
Display	North-facing window box, shaded balcony,

Huge range of colors: red, orange, coral, pink, white, lavender, and bicolors. Does not need deadheading — old flowers drop cleanly. New Guinea Impatiens (*I. hawkeri*) are slightly sun-tolerant and have larger flowers.

Begonias (*Begonia* spp.)

MILDLY TOXIC TO CATS AND DOGS – the tubers/roots are most toxic; plant material causes vomiting and salivation.

Incredibly versatile. Every begonia can thrive in partial shade outdoor conditions.

Light	Partial shade to bright indirect
Water	Allow top inch to dry between waterings
Temperature	55–80°F
Container	8–12" pot, hanging basket
Display	Shaded balcony, window box, hanging bask

Types

- Wax Begonias (*B. × semperflorens-cultorum*) – The standard bedding begonia; masses of small flowers; compact; continuous bloom; some sun tolerance
- Tuberous Begonias (*B. × tuberhybrida*) – Very large showy flowers; trailing or upright; spectacular; require more care
- Rex Begonias (*B. rex*) – Grown for extraordinary leaf patterns; metallic, swirled, and spotted patterns; less flowering
- Angel Wing Begonias (*B. coccinea* types) – Large wing-shaped spotted leaves; arching stems; excellent indoors or shaded outdoor
- *Boliviensis types (Santa Cruz Sunset, Bonfire) – Trailing; fire-red narrow flowers; excellent in hanging baskets; extended heat tolerance

Coleus (Plectranthus scutellarioides)

Safe for pets. The most spectacular foliage plant for shade. Hundreds of color combinations available.

Light	Partial to full shade; variegated types
Water	Keep consistently moist
Temperature	65-85°F; tropical
Container	8-12" pot, window box, hanging basket
Display	Any shaded container; stunning in groups

Coleus comes in virtually every color combination: red, pink, orange, yellow, lime, chocolate, black, copper, cream, and every blend between them. The sheer variety makes it one of the most customizable container plants. Pinch flower buds to maintain leaf production and bushiness.

Notable varieties: Kong Series (enormous leaves), Wizard Series (compact), Chocolate Mint (brown with green edges), ColorBlaze (prolific range), Solar Flare.



Heuchera / Coral Bells (Heuchera spp.)

Safe for pets. Stunning foliage in burgundy, orange, lime, silver, and caramel. Perennial.

Light	Partial shade to bright indirect; some d
Water	Allow top inch to dry between waterings
Temperature	50–80°F; frost hardy (perennial to zone
Container	10–14" pot
Display	Mixed partial-shade container, accent pl

Notable varieties: Palace Purple (deep burgundy), Lime Rickey (chartreuse), Caramel (warm amber), Midnight Rose (purple with pink spots), Berry Smoothie (pink-fuchsia), Silver Scrolls (silver with purple veins).

Violas and Pansies (*Viola × wittrockiana*)

Safe for pets. Edible flowers. Cold-tolerant bloomers for spring and fall when summer flowers fail.

Light	Partial shade to full sun (partial shade
Water	Keep moist
Temperature	40–65°F; thrive in cool weather; decline
Container	6–10" pot, window box
Display	Spring and fall window boxes, early-seas

Violas (small flowers) are more heat-tolerant than pansies (large flowers). Both have edible flowers used as garnishes, in salads, as cake decoration, and frozen into ice cubes. Pansy flowers taste faintly of wintergreen. Replace with heat-tolerant summer flowers when temperatures exceed 70°F consistently.



Hostas (Hosta spp.)

Safe for pets. The definitive shade garden plant. Dramatic foliage in containers.

Light	Full shade to partial shade; blue hostas
Water	Keep consistently moist
Temperature	40–80°F; frost hardy (perennial to zone
Container	12–20" pot depending on size
Display	Large floor container, accent planter fo

Compact Varieties for Containers

- Sum and Substance — Giant golden-green; can fill a 20" pot
- Halcyon — Blue-grey; medium; slug-resistant
- June — Blue and yellow variegated; medium; stunning
- Guacamole — Large; apple-green with dark edge; fragrant flowers
- Mini varieties (Mouse Ears, Blue Mouse Ears, Tiny Tears) — Excellent for smaller pots

SECTION THREE: JARS, BOTTLES, AND WATER VESSELS

No containers, no soil, no drainage holes required. A mason jar, a glass bottle, or a shallow tray is sufficient. This section covers sprouts (fastest food you can grow), water-grown plants, regrowth projects, and aquatic species.

PART A: SPROUTS AND MICROGREENS IN JARS

Sprouts are seeds germinated in a jar or tray. No light needed during sprouting; indirect light helps once greens form. No soil. Just water, seeds, and a clean container. First harvest in 3–7 days.

Equipment needed: Quart mason jar with mesh lid (or cheesecloth secured with a rubber band), sprouting tray, or hemp/jute growing mat for microgreens.

Basic Method (jar sprouting):

1. Rinse seeds; soak overnight in the jar with water (2–3× volume of seeds)
2. Drain; rinse twice daily; prop jar at angle to drain
3. Harvest when sprouts are 1–3" long and first tiny leaves appear
4. Rinse before eating; store in refrigerator for up to 5 days

Alfalfa Sprouts (*Medicago sativa*)

The classic sprout. Mild flavor; nutritional powerhouse. 4–6 days to harvest.

Fine, hair-like sprouts with tiny green leaves. Soaking time: 4–6 hours. Harvest at 1–2". Use in sandwiches, salads, wraps. Very high in vitamins C, K, and folate. One tablespoon of seeds produces a full quart of sprouts.

Broccoli Sprouts (*Brassica oleracea* var. *italica*)

The most nutritionally significant sprout. Extremely high in sulforaphane — a potent cancer-fighting compound. 5–7 days.

Peppery flavor; good in sandwiches and salads. Three-day broccoli sprouts contain 10–100x more sulforaphane than mature broccoli. One tablespoon of seeds yields a full jar. Soak for 6 hours; rinse twice daily.

Radish Sprouts (*Raphanus sativus*)

Spicy, peppery, fast. 4–6 days. Striking pink or white stems with bright green leaves.

Good in Asian dishes, eggs, and sandwiches for a sharp bite. Some varieties (China Rose radish seeds) produce striking pink stems. Soak 4 hours; harvest when 1–2" tall.

Mung Bean Sprouts (*Vigna radiata*)

The classic Asian bean sprout found in stir-fry and pho. Crisp and mild. 4–5 days.

Requires keeping in darkness or covered with a cloth for the first 2–3 days to develop the thick white stems.

Use in stir-fry, pad thai, spring rolls, and salads. Soak 8–12 hours; rinse 3x daily; keep in dim conditions.

Lentil Sprouts (*Lens culinaris*)

Nutty and mild. 4–6 days. Use green or French lentils (red lentils do not sprout reliably).

Excellent in salads, wraps, and grain bowls. High in protein and folate. Soak 8 hours; rinse twice daily. Harvest at 1/4" to 1" depending on preference — shorter is crunchier, longer is more leafy.

Sunflower Sprouts (*Helianthus annuus*)

Crunchy, nutty, substantial. 7–10 days. One of the most popular microgreens.

Use unhulled sunflower seeds. Best grown on a thin layer of potting mix or growing mat rather than jar-sprouted. Harvest with scissors when 2–3" tall and first leaves fully open. Excellent in salads and wraps — the most satisfying texture of any microgreen.

Pea Shoots (*Pisum sativum*)

Sweet, fresh, and substantial. 7–10 days. Tendrils and all are edible.

Soak dried whole peas for 8–12 hours; plant on 1–2" of growing mix in a shallow tray. Cover for the first 3–4 days. Harvest with scissors when 3–5" tall. Sweet pea flavor; excellent stir-fried, in salads, or as a garnish. One of the most productive microgreens per tray.

Wheatgrass (*Triticum aestivum*)

Intensely nutritious; 7–10 days. Juice or blend into smoothies.

Plant densely on 1–2" of growing mix. Soak wheat berries 12 hours; plant; cover 3–4 days; then expose to indirect light. Harvest when 6–7" tall. Juice in a wheatgrass juicer or masticating juicer; blend with fruit for a palatable daily shot. Very high in chlorophyll, iron, and B vitamins.

Fenugreek Sprouts (*Trigonella foenum-graecum*)

Strong maple-syrup aroma. 3–5 days. Essential in Indian cooking; excellent tea additive.

Slightly bitter when raw; improves with light cooking. Used in Indian dals, curries, and flatbreads. Soak 4–6 hours; rinse twice daily. Harvest at 1–2". Very fast.

Chickpea Sprouts (*Cicer arietinum*)

Nutty, firm, and protein-rich. 2–3 days for short sprouts; 4–5 days for longer ones.

Soak 12–16 hours; rinse twice daily. Harvest very short (1/4") and roast for a crispy snack, or let grow to 1" for use in salads and grain bowls. A firm, satisfying texture that other sprouts lack.

Clover Sprouts (*Trifolium* spp.)

Similar to alfalfa; slightly sweeter. 5–7 days. Rich in isoflavones.

Very similar growing method to alfalfa. Slightly more robust stems. Excellent in sandwiches and salads.

Buckwheat Microgreens (*Fagopyrum esculentum*)

Decorative, mild, and slightly nutty. 7–10 days. Hulled buckwheat only.

Must use hulled (groat) buckwheat, not the unhulled version. Grow on growing mix in a tray; harvest at 2–3" when cotyledons are fully open. Striking dark-red stems against bright green leaves. High in rutin (a bioflavonoid with cardiovascular benefits).

Red Cabbage Microgreens (*Brassica oleracea* var. *capitata* f. *rubra*)

Striking purple; mild, slightly peppery. 7–10 days.

Vivid magenta-purple stems and deep green-purple leaves. Excellent visual contrast in salads. Very high in anthocyanins (antioxidants responsible for the purple color).

Kale Microgreens (*Brassica oleracea* var. *acephala*)

Mild kale flavor; very nutritious. 8–12 days.

Less intense than mature kale; good for anyone who dislikes kale's bitterness. Excellent in smoothies.

Amaranth Microgreens (*Amaranthus* spp.)

Striking magenta-and-green color. Mild flavor. 7–10 days.

Purely ornamental for salad garnish and plating; nutritious. High in protein relative to most microgreens.

Basil Microgreens (*Ocimum basilicum*)

Intense basil fragrance and flavor in tiny form. 14–21 days (the slowest microgreen).

Use a thin layer of potting mix. Keep warm (70°F+). Harvest at cotyledon stage — the flavor is concentrated and remarkable. Worth the wait. Pairs with fresh tomatoes and burrata exactly as mature basil does.

PART B: WATER-ROOTED CUTTINGS AND HYDROPONIC VESSELS

Plants that root, live, and sometimes thrive indefinitely in water. Glass bottles and vases become living decorative elements.

Pothos in Water (*Epipremnum aureum*)

TOXIC TO CATS AND DOGS.

Pothos cuttings (a node + at least one leaf) root in water in 1-2 weeks and can live in a glass of water indefinitely. Change water weekly; add a single drop of liquid fertilizer monthly. Roots may grow to impressive lengths in a glass vase. The visual effect of long white roots in clear glass is striking. Place multiple cuttings in decorative glass bottles on a shelf — they trail and grow as living sculptures.

Sweet Potato Vine in Water (*Ipomoea batatas*)

Mildly toxic if ingested in large quantities; generally safe for pets in small amounts.

One of the most dramatic water-jar plants. Place a sweet potato (grocery store) in a jar of water (suspended with toothpicks, half submerged). Within 1–2 weeks, trailing vines with heart-shaped leaves emerge from the top and roots from the bottom. Can cascade several feet. Varieties with purple or bronze foliage are particularly striking.

Lucky Bamboo in Water (*Dracaena sanderiana*)

See full entry in Section 1B (Low Light Indoor). Lucky bamboo lives in shallow water with pebbles to anchor the stems. Excellent for glass vessels and decorative containers.

Basil Cuttings in Water

Take 4–6" cuttings just below a leaf node; remove lower leaves; place in a glass of water. Roots form in 1–2 weeks. You can harvest the top leaves while the cutting is rooting — basil in a glass of water on a bright windowsill is one of the most useful kitchen setups imaginable. Transplant to soil once roots are 2–3" long, or keep in water with regular fertilizer additions.

Mint Cuttings in Water

Mint roots in water faster than any other herb — 5–7 days. Keeps fresh in a glass of water far longer than mint sold in plastic bags. Use as a countertop herb holder and root new plants simultaneously.

Green Onion Regrowth

See Section 1A (Edible/Bright Indirect). This is one of the most worthwhile kitchen habits: save scallion root ends (1–2") in a shallow glass with 1" of water. Fresh green tops in 3–5 days. Change water every 2 days. A single glass of root ends provides ongoing kitchen herbs indefinitely with only grocery store scraps.

Vegetable Regrowth from Scraps

The following vegetables regrow usable leaves and shoots from kitchen scraps placed in water:

Vegetable	Part to Save	What Regrows	Notes
Celery	Base (2" bottom)	New celery stalks	2-3 regrowth cycles possible
Romaine lettuce	Heart (bottom 2-3")	New inner leaves	Harvest when 3-4" tall
Bok choy	Base (2")	New leaves and shoots	Fast; multiple harvests
Fennel	Base (2")	New fronds	Fennel fronds are edible; mild anise fla
Beet	Top (1/2" above root)	Edible beet greens	Place cut side down in shallow water
Carrot	Top (1/2" above root)	Carrot greens for garnish	Carrot greens are edible (slightly bitte
Garlic (sprouted)	Single clove	Garlic shoots/greens	Place in shallow water; harvest shoots
Lemongrass	Stalk base	New growth	Root in water, then transplant

Reality check: These regrowth projects produce limited yields — a handful of greens, not a full harvest. Their value is culinary (fresh herbs and garnish), educational, and decorative. They are not a food production strategy, but they are a satisfying, zero-cost kitchen practice.

Watercress in Water

See full entry in Section 1A. Watercress grows directly in a shallow tray of water — arguably its ideal apartment environment. Change water every 2–3 days. Harvest tops continuously.

Hydroponics — Simple Kratky Method

The Kratky method is a passive hydroponic technique requiring no pumps, electricity, or timers. A plant is suspended in a net pot over a reservoir of nutrient solution. As the plant drinks, an air gap forms above the water, providing oxygen to the roots.

What you need:

- Opaque container (5-gallon bucket, mason jar, or purpose-built reservoir)
- Net cups
- Hydroponic nutrient solution (General Hydroponics FloraGro, or similar)
- Growing medium (clay pebbles or rockwool)
- Seeds or transplants

Best crops for Kratky in apartments:

- Lettuce (fastest, most rewarding; harvest in 30–35 days)
- Spinach
- Basil
- Kale
- Herbs generally
- Bok choy

One 5-gallon bucket per large lettuce plant; one mason jar per small plant or herb. Set up under any indirect light or grow light. No maintenance between refills.

PART C: AQUATIC AND SEMI-AQUATIC PLANTS

For those who want a water garden on their windowsill or balcony.

Duckweed (Lemna minor)

Safe for pets. Edible and highly nutritious. Fastest plant growth rate known — doubles in 2–3 days in good conditions.

Container	Wide bowl, aquarium, or bucket
Light	Bright indirect to full sun
Water	Still or slow-moving water

Tiny floating plants, each 1–5mm across. Grow in a wide vessel on a sunny windowsill or balcony. Harvest by skimming the surface. High in protein (30–40% by dry weight), omega-3 fatty acids, and B12. Eaten in Southeast Asia. Growing rapidly in international interest as a sustainable protein. Use in smoothies, soups, or dried and powdered as a food supplement.



Lotus (Nelumbo spp.) — Dwarf Varieties

Safe for pets. Sacred, beautiful, and surprisingly manageable in a large container.

Container	Large tub (minimum 15–20 gallons); no dr
Light	Full sun
Water	Submerged in still water; 4–6" above tub

Dwarf varieties (Momo Botan, Alba Grandiflora, Chawan Basu) can grow in large containers on sunny balconies. Flowers in summer; one of the most spectacular plants you can grow in a container. The lotus also produces edible seed pods, seeds, rhizomes, and young leaves — virtually the entire plant is edible.

Water Lettuce (*Pistia stratiotes*)

Decorative floating plant for outdoor water vessels on full-sun balconies. Extremely fast-growing.

Container	Tub, barrel, or large decorative pot wit
Light	Full sun
Water	Floats on still water
Note	Invasive in Florida, California, and Gul

Velvet-textured pale green rosettes float on the water surface. Root system hangs below as a dramatic fringe. Removes nutrients and heavy metals from water (bioremediation). Not edible.

Dwarf Papyrus (Cyperus isocladius)

Safe for pets. Architectural and dramatic. Grows in a pot of water.

Container	Pot submerged in water bowl, or pot sitt
Light	Bright indirect to full sun
Water	Constantly wet; pot can sit in standing

Miniature version of the papyrus used to make paper in ancient Egypt. Umbrella-shaped clusters of delicate threadlike stems. Excellent in containers of standing water on balconies. Tolerates indoor bright indirect light.

SECTION FOUR: INDOOR PLANTS — WITH A GROW LIGHT

A full-spectrum LED grow light changes the calculus of apartment growing completely. A 2-foot panel or a clip-on grow lamp over a shelf transforms a windowless counter into a productive growing space. Run 14–16 hours per day, 6–12 inches above plants.

LED grow light recommendations:

- Seedling/microgreens/herbs: Any T5 or panel LED at 20–40W actual draw
- Tomatoes/peppers/fruiting crops: 200–400W actual draw (or equivalent photon flux)
- General purpose: Mars Hydro TS-600, AC Infinity Ionframe, Spider Farmer SF-1000 are commonly cited mid-tier options
- Budget/tabletop: 20W–45W clip-on or bar-style lights work well for herbs and greens

ALL HERBS UNDER GROW LIGHT

Every herb listed in this guide grows excellently under a quality full-spectrum grow light at 14–16 hours per day. This especially benefits:

- Basil — Produces at its absolute best; flavor rivals outdoor plants
 - Rosemary — Grows faster and more compactly than in indirect window light
 - Oregano, thyme, sage — All perform well; the light makes up for the absence of hot sun
 - Cilantro — The grow light actually causes cilantro to bolt faster due to the extended hours; use 12 hours/day for cilantro and parsley specifically
-

Tomatoes Under Grow Light (*Solanum lycopersicum*)

Cherry and patio tomato varieties grow and produce under high-output grow lights (200W+ actual draw). This is not a casual undertaking — tomatoes need a lot of light. A single 400W LED or two strong 200W panels, running 16 hours per day, positioned 6–12 inches above the plants, can produce an ongoing harvest from compact determinate varieties year-round.

Best varieties for indoor grow light: Tiny Tim, Tumbling Tom, Florida Petite, Patio. Provide support for fruit-bearing stems; hand pollinate with a soft brush or vibrating toothpick (tapping the flower cluster) to replace wind pollination.

Peppers Under Grow Light (*Capsicum* spp.)

More forgiving than tomatoes under grow lights. Compact varieties (jalapeño, shishito, Thai hot) do well under medium-output LED at 12–16 hours. Bring balcony pepper plants indoors under a grow light in fall — peppers are perennial and a well-maintained plant can continue producing for 3–5 years.

Lettuces and Greens Under Grow Light

The most rewarding grow-light crop. 20W–40W actual draw, 14 hours per day, 4–6" above plants. A single 2-foot shelf with a grow-light bar can cycle through continuous lettuce, spinach, arugula, and Asian green harvests year-round. The economics are excellent: seeds are cheap, yield is consistent, and fresh salad greens have high grocery store value.

Microgreens Under Grow Light

A grow light elevates microgreen production from occasional trays to a serious continuous operation. Stagger trays every 5–7 days for uninterrupted daily harvests. A simple wire shelving unit with grow-light bars on each shelf becomes a productive food production system in a few square feet.

Strawberries Under Grow Light

Everbearing strawberries under a quality LED (200W+, 14–16 hours) produce continuously indoors. This requires patience to establish plants and hand pollination. The reward is fresh strawberries in winter.

Cacti and Succulents Under Grow Light

Most cacti and succulents that struggle in dim apartments thrive under grow lights. This is particularly valuable for:

- Echeveria — Maintains tight, colorful rosette form; etiolates (stretches) without adequate light
 - Haworthia — Already among the most tolerant; grows faster and more vigorously under light
 - Aloe vera — TOXIC TO CATS AND DOGS — beneficial sap does not extend to pets
 - Crassula (Jade Plant) — TOXIC TO CATS AND DOGS; blooms more readily with grow light
 - Sedum — Compact, colorful; many varieties
 - Gasteria — Very tolerant; aloe relative; compact
 - Lithops (Living Stones) — Need very bright light; grow light or south window only
 - Christmas Cactus (Schlumbergera) — Safe for pets; grows and blooms excellently under light
-

Orchids Under Grow Light

Phalaenopsis and other orchids that struggle to rebloom in dim apartments reliably rebloom under a full-spectrum grow light at 12–14 hours per day. Position the light 12–18 inches above the crown. The increased and consistent light duration simulates tropical seasonality and triggers the hormonal response that initiates spike development.

SECTION FIVE: TOOLS, CONTAINERS, AND CARE

The right container and the right tools determine whether your plants thrive or merely survive. This section is not about buying more — it's about buying the right things once.

CHOOSING THE RIGHT CONTAINER

Terra Cotta Pots

Best for: Herbs, Mediterranean plants, succulents, cacti, rosemary, lavender, anything that needs excellent drainage

Advantages:

- Porous clay wicks moisture from the soil; prevents overwatering
- Breathes — allows air exchange through pot walls
- Heavy and stable; will not blow off a balcony in wind
- Beautiful; improves with age as mineral deposits form

Disadvantages:

- Dries out quickly (requires more frequent watering)
- Heavy (important consideration for balcony load limits)
- Breaks when dropped or frozen

Best practice: Group terra cotta pots together to slow moisture loss through the sides.

Plastic Pots

Best for: Water-hungry plants (tomatoes, cucumbers, basil), moisture-loving tropicals, most edibles

Advantages:

- Retains moisture longer than terra cotta — better for heavy drinkers
- Lightweight
- Inexpensive
- Available in large sizes

Disadvantages:

- Restricts air to roots
 - Can become brittle with UV exposure outdoors over years
 - Less attractive (use as cachepot liners inside decorative pots)
-

Fabric Grow Bags

Best for: Tomatoes, peppers, potatoes, sweet potatoes, any large edible that benefits from air pruning

Advantages:

- Air-prunes roots — when roots reach the bag edge and encounter air, they stop growing and branch back, producing a dense, fibrous root system that is more efficient
- Lightweight
- Folds flat for storage
- Prevents waterlogging

Disadvantages:

- Dries out faster than plastic (in summer heat, may need twice-daily watering)
- Wears out after 2–3 seasons with outdoor UV exposure
- Requires elevated placement to drain properly

Best sizes: 5-gallon for peppers and herbs; 10-gallon for tomatoes; 25–50 gallon for root vegetables and small fruit trees.

Self-Watering Planters

Best for: Lettuce, herbs, flowers, anything that needs consistent moisture; frequent travelers; anyone who regularly forgets to water

How they work: A reservoir in the base stores water. A wick or wicking soil draws water upward into the root zone as the plant needs it. Top soil remains dry; roots access moisture from below. Refill the reservoir every 3–14 days depending on plant and season.

Best options:

- EarthBox — Classic self-watering system; excellent for tomatoes and vegetables on balconies
 - Lechuza — Premium German-made; elegant for indoor use; many sizes
 - Bloem Ariana — Affordable; good for herbs and flowers
 - Window planter boxes with built-in reservoirs — Excellent for balcony rails
-

Window Boxes and Railing Planters

Best for: Herbs, lettuce, flowers, Asian greens, radishes, shallow-rooted crops

Most balcony railing planters are designed to attach to standard railing widths (2–4"). Measure your railing before purchasing. Over-railing planters distribute weight along the railing rather than concentrating it; confirm your balcony railing can support the weight when filled (soil is heavy — 10–15 lbs per cubic foot).

Note on weight: This is not a trivial concern. A long window box filled with wet soil can weigh 40–60 lbs. Check your lease, building codes, and balcony load rating before hanging heavy planters on a railing.

Hanging Planters and Baskets

Best for: Trailing plants (pothos, ivy, trailing petunias, fuchsia, strawberries, trailing tomatoes)

Types:

- Wire coco-liner baskets — Classic; good drainage; needs frequent watering
- Fabric hanging planters — Lightweight; good drainage; dries quickly
- Ceramic hanging pots — Beautiful; heavy; better for indoor use
- Macramé hangers — Hold a standard pot; excellent for displaying houseplants at height

Ceiling vs. command hooks: Indoors, 3M Command hooks rated 5–7.5 lbs handle most hanging planters. For heavier planters, anchor into a stud or ceiling joist. Outdoors, use weatherproof hardware rated for the full wet weight.

Cachepots and Decorative Containers

A cachepot is a decorative outer container that holds a plain nursery pot. The plant grows in the nursery pot (with drainage) and sits inside the decorative pot (without drainage). Empty the cachepot of standing water after each watering to prevent root rot.

This system separates function from aesthetics — use the correct pot for the plant's needs, and the correct pot for your decor. Almost any watertight container becomes a planter this way: ceramic bowls, wicker baskets (line with plastic), vintage tins, colanders, wooden crates.

SUPPORT STRUCTURES

Trellises and Vertical Growing

For balconies and outdoor spaces:

- Obelisk/tower trellis — Freestanding; excellent for cucumbers, beans, and peas in large containers
- A-frame trellis — Spans two containers; efficient use of vertical space
- Cable system or wire grid — Attach to balcony wall using adhesive or tension mounts; discreet and strong
- Bamboo poles and twine — The cheapest, most versatile option; tie horizontally every 8–12 inches for climbing plants
- Balcony railing as trellis — Train cucumbers or beans directly along the railing; the horizontal bars do the job

For indoor climbing plants:

- Moss pole — For Monstera, Philodendron, pothos — the aerial roots attach to the damp moss; the plant climbs vertically and produces larger leaves; keep the moss moist by misting or drip irrigation
 - Coconut coir pole — Similar to moss pole but drier; less maintenance
 - Wooden dowel — Simple support for tall single-stem plants
 - Wire hoop — For smaller plants; compact and tidy
-

Stakes

- Bamboo stakes — Cheap, strong, and biodegradable; cut to size; use for tomatoes, peppers, tall herbs
 - Metal wire stakes — More permanent; reusable; better for heavy plants
 - Spiral tomato stakes — Thread a determinate tomato up a spiral stake; no tying required
 - Plant clips and ties — Soft silicone or foam ties for attaching stems to supports without damage
-

WATERING TOOLS AND IRRIGATION

Watering Cans

The single most important tool. Choose one with a **long, narrow spout** for directing water to the soil and avoiding foliage. A **fine rose attachment** (perforated head) is essential for seedlings and microgreens.

Good features:

- Long neck for reaching hanging baskets and tall plants
 - 1-2 gallon capacity (smaller is lighter and easier to control)
 - Removable rose head
-

Watering Globes / Aqua Stakes

How they work: A glass or plastic globe (or terracotta spike) with a long neck. Fill with water; insert the neck into the soil. Water slowly releases through the porous tip as the soil dries. Provides consistent slow moisture for 1–2 weeks.

Best for: Houseplants, succulents (very slow release), and any plant you are away from for 1–2 weeks. **Not suitable for water-hungry edibles** (tomatoes, basil) – the release rate is too slow for their needs.

Types:

- Glass globes – Beautiful; standard; 1–2 week water delivery
 - Terracotta spikes with bottle attachment – Insert a wine bottle filled with water; effective and free after the first purchase
 - Drip stakes – Connect to a water container with thin plastic tubing; adjustable flow rate
-

Drip Irrigation and Timers

For balcony container gardens with multiple large plants (tomatoes, peppers, cucumbers), a drip irrigation system on a timer is the single most impactful quality-of-life upgrade. Water usage decreases; plant health improves (consistent moisture vs. boom-and-bust watering); and you can leave for a week without worry.

System: Connect a water timer to an outdoor spigot (or use a portable gravity-fed reservoir). Run 1/4" tubing to each container with an adjustable drip emitter. Set to run daily (usually early morning). Adjust emitters for each plant's water needs.

Portable balcony options: Self-contained drip systems with a gravity reservoir or small pump work without a spigot connection.

Spray Bottles and Misters

Essential for:

- Misting humidity-loving plants (ferns, calathea, orchids)
- Watering newly seeded trays and microgreens
- Misting moss poles to keep them moist

Use filtered or distilled water for plants sensitive to chlorine and fluoride (ferns, calathea, most orchids).

Moisture Meters

A simple probe meter (\$10–15) inserted into soil reads moisture level on a 1–10 scale. Eliminates guesswork and is especially valuable for:

- Succulents and cacti (water only at 2–3 or below)
 - Orchids (water at 3–4)
 - Most houseplants (water at 3–4)
 - Vegetables and herbs (water at 4–5)
-

Humidity Trays (Pebble Trays)

Fill a wide tray with pebbles; add water to just below the top of the pebbles. Place pots on top. As the water evaporates, it raises humidity around the plants. Effective for ferns, calathea, orchids, and tropical houseplants in dry apartments.

Alternatively: group humidity-loving plants together; their transpiration creates a localized humid microclimate.

SOIL, FERTILIZER, AND AMENDMENTS

Potting Mix

Never use garden soil in containers — it compacts and drains poorly.

Mix Type	Best For
Standard all-purpose potting mix	Most houseplants, herbs, flowers
Moisture-retaining mix (with moisture cr	Hanging baskets, water-hungry edibles
Well-draining mix (add 30% perlite to st	Succulents, cacti, Mediterranean herbs
Acid potting mix (ericaceous)	Blueberries, azaleas, camellias (pH 4.5–
Seed starting mix	Starting seeds; fine texture; no fertili
Raised bed / vegetable mix	Large outdoor containers for vegetables

Fertilizers

Type	Best For	How Often
Slow-release granular (Osmocote, etc.)	All container plants; set-and-forget for	Every 3–6 months
Balanced liquid (10-10-10)	All plants during active growth	Every 2–4 weeks
Tomato fertilizer (high K, e.g., 5-10-10)	Tomatoes, peppers, fruiting crops	Weekly during fruiting
Herb fertilizer (light nitrogen)	Culinary herbs	Every 4–6 weeks
Orchid fertilizer (low phosphorus)	Orchids	"Weakly, weekly" – 1/4 strength weekly
Cactus fertilizer	Cacti, succulents	Monthly in spring/summer; not in winter
Fish emulsion	All edibles	Every 2–3 weeks; effective organic optio

Key rule: Container plants need more frequent feeding than in-ground plants because watering flushes nutrients from the soil. When in doubt, fertilize at half the recommended rate and twice as often.

Useful Amendments

- Perlite — White volcanic glass beads; improves drainage; add 20–30% to standard mix for Mediterranean herbs and succulents
 - Vermiculite — Improves moisture retention; use in seed starting mix
 - Coarse sand (horticultural grade) — Additional drainage; do not use beach or builder's sand
 - Worm castings — Gentle organic fertilizer; add a handful to any potting mix at planting
 - Coir (coconut fiber) — Sustainable peat substitute; good water retention; neutral pH
-

PET SAFETY REFERENCE

All pet safety warnings throughout this guide are consolidated here. This list is not exhaustive. Always verify with ASPCA Poison Control (aspca.org/pet-care/animal-poison-control) or your veterinarian for any plant you are unsure about.

HIGHLY TOXIC — AVOID IN HOMES WITH PETS

Plant	Toxin/Effect	Notes
Dieffenbachia	Insoluble calcium oxalates; intense oral	Do not grow if pets or children may chew
Lilies (Easter, Tiger, Day, Asiatic)	Renal failure in cats; even small amount	Extremely dangerous for cats; keep none
Sago Palm (Cycas revoluta)	Cycasin; liver failure; highly fatal	All parts toxic; seeds most dangerous
Oleander (Nerium oleander)	Cardiac glycosides; heart failure	One leaf can kill a dog
Azalea / Rhododendron	Grayanotoxins; vomiting, weakness, coma	Keep off all balconies with pet access
Foxglove (Digitalis)	Cardiac glycosides	Highly toxic; avoid
Autumn Crocus (Colchicum)	Colchicine; multi-organ failure	More toxic than spring crocus

TOXIC — KEEP OUT OF REACH

Plant	Effect	Pets Affected
Pothos	Oral irritation, vomiting, drooling	Cats and dogs
Philodendron	Oral irritation, swelling	Cats and dogs
Peace Lily	Oral irritation, drooling	Cats and dogs
Monstera	Oral irritation, GI upset	Cats and dogs
ZZ Plant	Vomiting, diarrhea	Cats and dogs
Snake Plant / Sansevieria	Nausea, vomiting	Cats and dogs
Chinese Evergreen	Oral irritation	Cats and dogs
Rubber Plant	Skin and GI irritation (latex sap)	Cats and dogs
Dracaena / Corn Plant	Vomiting, lethargy	Cats and dogs
Jade Plant	Vomiting, incoordination	Cats and dogs
Aloe Vera	GI upset, lethargy	Cats and dogs
English Ivy	Vomiting, diarrhea	Cats and dogs
Umbrella Plant (Schefflera)	Oral irritation	Cats and dogs
Lantana	Vomiting, liver damage	Cats and dogs
Geraniums (Pelargonium)	Vomiting, skin irritation	Cats and dogs
Amaryllis	Vomiting, diarrhea, tremors	Cats and dogs
Tulips (bulb most toxic)	GI irritation, central nervous system is	Cats and dogs
Daffodil (bulb most toxic)	GI distress, cardiac issues	Cats and dogs
Morning Glory (seeds)	Hallucinations, GI distress	All pets and humans
Wisteria (seeds/pods)	GI distress, dizziness	Cats and dogs
Kalanchoe	Vomiting, cardiac issues	Cats and dogs
Cyclamen	GI distress, cardiac issues	Cats and dogs
Anthurium	Oral irritation, drooling	Cats and dogs
Begonia (tubers most toxic)	Vomiting, salivation	Cats and dogs
Caladium	Oral irritation, swelling	Cats and dogs

GENERALLY SAFE FOR CATS AND DOGS

Plant
Spider Plant (<i>Chlorophytum comosum</i>)
African Violet (<i>Saintpaulia</i>)
Boston Fern, Bird's Nest Fern, most fern
Orchids (<i>Phalaenopsis</i> , <i>Cattleya</i> , <i>Dendrob</i>)
Calathea / Maranta / Prayer Plant
Peperomia
Hoya / Wax Plant
Bromeliads (including <i>Tillandsia</i> air pla
Nerve Plant (<i>Fittonia</i>)
Pilea (Chinese Money Plant)
Christmas Cactus (<i>Schlumbergera</i>)
Cast Iron Plant (<i>Aspidistra</i>)
Parlor Palm (<i>Chamaedorea elegans</i>)
Areca Palm (<i>Dypsis lutescens</i>)
Swedish Ivy (<i>Plectranthus</i>)
Impatiens
Petunias
Marigolds (<i>Tagetes</i>)
Zinnias
Cosmos
Sunflowers
Fuchsia (including edible berries)
Violas / Pansies
Heuchera / Coral Bells
Hostas
Haworthia
Most culinary herbs (mint, basil, rosema
Most edible vegetables and greens
Strawberries
Lucky Bamboo (<i>Dracaena sanderiana</i>)

Important: "Generally safe" means not typically life-threatening if a small amount is ingested, not that eating the plant is beneficial for pets. Large quantities of even safe plants can cause GI upset. Monitor pets, particularly kittens and puppies, and contact your vet if you observe unusual symptoms.

The ASPCA Animal Poison Control Center emergency number: (888) 426-4435. There may be a consultation fee.

QUICK REFERENCE: PLANTS BY SPACE TYPE

"I Have Only North-Facing Windows"

Your best options:

- ZZ plant, pothos, cast iron plant, philodendron, peace lily, parlor palm, Chinese evergreen
 - Lucky bamboo in water; scallion regrowth in water
 - Sprouts and microgreens (need almost no light)
 - Consider: even a modest grow light completely changes your possibilities
-

"I Have an East-Facing Window"

Your best options:

- Mint, chives, parsley, sorrel, lemon balm, chervil, lettuce, spinach, arugula
 - All shade-tolerant ornamentals from Section 1A
 - African violet, orchids, ferns, calathea, hoya
-

"I Have a Sunny Balcony"

Your best options:

- Cherry tomatoes, peppers, cucumbers, beans, herbs (all), strawberries, dwarf blueberries
 - Meyer lemon, fig, ground cherries
 - Geraniums, petunias, marigolds, zinnias, lavender, sunflowers
-

"I Have a Shaded Balcony or Fire Escape"

Your best options:

- Lettuce, spinach, arugula, mint, parsley, cilantro, Asian greens, alpine strawberries
 - Fuchsia, impatiens, begonias, coleus, heuchera, hostas, violas
-

"I Have No Space at All"

Your best options:

- Mason jar sprouts (counter space only)
 - Scallion and herb cuttings in water glasses
 - One pothos or one spider plant
 - One self-watering African violet
 - A microgreen tray under a small grow light
-

"I Travel Frequently"

Your best options:

- Self-watering planters for herbs and flowers
 - Watering globes for individual pots
 - ZZ plants, succulents, cast iron plants (survive 2+ weeks without water)
 - Drip timer system for balcony container gardens
 - A plant-sitting arrangement with a neighbor for water-hungry edibles
-

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If you found this guide useful, you might also like:

- The Apartment Plant Catalog (\$14) — Detailed profiles for 80+ edible and decorative plants matched to your indoor conditions
- Container Growing Blueprint Pack (\$12) — Five printable layout plans for maximizing every square foot of balcony or patio
- 12-Month Urban Growing Planner (\$7) — Week-by-week schedule so you never miss a planting window

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